CHAPTER 6

Initial Stage of a Group

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CHAPTER LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Identify and define the key characteristics of a group during the initial stage
2. Explore ways to deal with conflict early in a group
3. Examine a framework for effective ways to establish trust in a group
4. Explain ways to assist members in defining personal goals for group participation
5. Discuss the specific therapeutic factors and how they contribute to group effectiveness (CACREP, 2016, Standard C)
6. Understand research findings on effective therapeutic relationships
7. Delineate guidelines for getting the most from a group experience
8. Examine some of the major issues facing coleaders during the initial stage
9. Explore guidelines for opening and closing group sessions

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You have just completed your first session with a group of sexual abuse survivors. Several of the members were very quiet throughout the meeting, and others expressed a high degree of anxiety. One member tended to dominate the session. She interrupted others while they were speaking and often moved the discussion away from other members back onto herself by saying how she could "relate" to what they were saying.

Issues of trust and anxiety are common in initial sessions. Consider interventions you can make that will help create trust. How can you assist members in exploring any fears they may have over participating in a group? Reflect on these questions:

- How might you address the issues of trust and anxiety that seem to permeate this group? What do you think will help the silent members feel safe enough to share?
- How might you invite members to identify and explore any sources of their anxiety?
- What ideas do you have for addressing the member who dominated the discussion?
- What possible "function" does a talkative member's behavior serve in the group dynamics?
- Which members (quiet, anxious, or dominant) would be most challenging for you as the group leader?

Introduction

This chapter contains many examples of teaching members about how groups function. We describe the characteristics of a group in its early stages, discuss the importance of creating trust as the foundation for a group, explore the topic of establishing goals early in the life of a group, discuss formation of group norms and the beginnings of group cohesion, explain research findings on effective therapeutic relationships, and provide guidelines for helping members get the most from a group. We also suggest some leadership guidelines for opening and closing group meetings.

LO1

Group Characteristics at the Initial Stage

The central process during the initial stage of a group is orientation and exploration. Members are getting acquainted, learning how the group functions, developing spoken and unspoken norms that will govern group behavior, exploring their fears and hopes pertaining to the group, clarifying their expectations, identifying personal goals, and determining whether this group is safe. This stage is characterized by members expressing fears and hesitations as well as hopes and expectations. The degree of trust that can be established in the group will be determined by how the leader deals with these reactions.

Some Early Concerns

It is common during the initial phase of a group that members may appear rather hesitant to get involved. Caution on the part of members is to be expected, and

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it makes sense. Participants are often tentative and vague about what they hope to get from a group experience. Most members are uncertain about group norms and expected behavior, and there may be moments of silence and awkwardness. Some members may be impatient and ready to work, whereas others may appear hesitant or uninvolved. Still others may be looking for quick solutions to their problems. If your leadership style involves very little structure, the level of anxiety is likely to be high because of the ambiguity of the situation, and there will probably be hesitation and requests from members for direction. Members may ask "What are we supposed to be doing?" or state "I really don't know what we should be talking about." When someone does volunteer a problem for discussion, other members are likely to offer suggestions and give what they consider to be helpful advice. Although this may seem like progress because there is the appearance of group interaction, giving advice bypasses the necessity for members to explore their problems and discover their own solutions.

During the first few group sessions, members watch the leader's behavior and think about safety in the group. Trust can be lost or gained by how the leader handles conflict or the initial expression of any negative reactions. The group leader's task is to be aware of the tentative nature of explorations during these early sessions and to treat critical comments nondefensively and with acceptance.

Initial Hesitation and Cultural Considerations

Many group members hold attitudes and expectations that make it difficult for them to participate fully in a group experience. In some cultures, individuals are discouraged from expressing their feelings openly, talking about their personal problems with people they do not know well, or telling others how they perceive or react to them. Group practitioners need to be aware that hesitation to participate in a group may be more the result of cultural background than of an uncooperative attitude. For example, Latinos/as may approach people cautiously because of their experiences with oppression, discrimination, and marginalization (Torres-Rivera, Torres Fernandez, & Hendricks, 2014). Some African American clients may experience difficulty in a group, especially if they are expected to make deeply personal disclosures too quickly. In general, group counselors need to be aware of the heritage, values, and background of African American clients and incorporate them into group work (Steen, Shi, & Hockersmith, 2014). Group leaders can encourage members to say something about what makes their participation difficult. Rather than ignoring members, the leader can invite members to explore how they can best benefit from the group experience.

In a group situation, individuals may seem to be reserved or "holding back" when they are only being true to their cultural values or gender-role norms. It is a mistake to assume that behaving cautiously is a sign of an uncooperative attitude. Some members may believe it is distasteful to talk publicly about private matters. Others may feel it is a sign of weakness to disclose personal problems or to express feelings. Those members who have cultural

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injunctions against talking about their family in a group may be reluctant to engage in role playing involving symbolically talking to their parents. They may not want to reveal certain struggles out of fear that their disclosures would entrench already existing stereotypes and prejudices. Members from certain racial, cultural, and ethnic populations have learned a healthy paranoia about self-disclosing too quickly in a group with members from a dominant population. Their experience of oppression and their reservations in making themselves known to others and determining who is safe in the group needs to be viewed in this context.

One of the groups I (Cindy) led was a woman's HIV prevention/education group that consisted of Caucasian, Latina, and African American women. Getting the women to discuss personal issues pertaining to sexual values and behaviors was a challenge. I designed the first meeting to address the differences among the members and to help draw out a discussion about the ways in which the women were both similar and different. Putting the topic of difference on the table enabled these women to share the concerns and fears they had about sitting in a diverse group of women. It also brought to their attention the many overlapping experiences and issues they shared with one another. This discussion set a tone for the rest of the group meetings, and group members talked openly about the ways their lives and sexual behaviors were influenced by their cultural identities.

In your role as a group leader you can minimize reluctance on the part of members by inviting a discussion of how they could participate in the group in a way that does not violate their cultural norms and values. If you are aware of the cultural context of the members of your group, it is possible to both appreciate their cultural values and respectfully encourage them to deal with the concerns that brought them to the group. An important leadership function is assisting members in understanding how their initial hesitation to reveal themselves may relate to their cultural conditioning. It is important to understand the role society has played with some members by oppressing them into silence or caution. These social factors shed a different light on the reluctance of some group members to engage in self-disclosure.

Regardless of the type of group, some hesitation is to be expected in the initial stage, even if people are eager to join the group. This reluctance can be manifested in many different ways. What members do talk about is likely to be less important than what they keep hidden—their real fears about being in this group at this moment. Because cautious behavior often arises from fearful expectations, identifying and discussing these fears now will benefit the whole group. It is not helpful to say to an anxious member: "You don't need to be afraid in here. Nobody will hurt you." You cannot honestly make such promises. Some members may feel hurt by another's response to them. It is helpful to let members know that you want them to express when they feel hurt and that you will not abandon them. Although members may make mistakes and step on each other's toes, it can be reassuring for members to know that this provides an opportunity to learn how to recover and to experiment with new behaviors in a supportive atmosphere.

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Learning in Action

Testing the Waters

By opening a dialogue about members' fears and hesitations, group members can learn to deal with these feelings in an honest and productive way. Discuss these questions as a group during an initial stage of group:

1. When faced with a task that is scary for you, how do you typically respond? Do you retreat or run away from the fear? Do you face the fear head on? Do you pretend that you are not afraid? Do you ask for support from others or work it out independently?
2. How do you predict you will behave in this group if you feel afraid?
3. Is your way of responding to fear the way you would like to behave, or is there anything about how you react that you would like to change?
4. If you felt afraid to participate in the group or to share a part of yourself, what could you do or say that would help you to move through your fear? How might the leaders or group members support you?

Identifying and Exploring Common Fears of Group Members

Members test the waters at the early sessions to see if their concerns will be taken seriously and if the group is a safe place to express what they think and feel. If their reactions, positive or negative, are listened to with respect and acceptance, they have a basis to begin dealing with deeper aspects of themselves. A good way for you to start dealing with members' fears is by listening to them and encouraging full expression of their concerns. Here are some common fears participants identify:

- Will I be accepted or rejected?
- Will others be able to understand me?
- How will this group be any different from other groups in which I have experienced discrimination, oppression, and prejudice?
- I'm afraid of being judged by others, especially if I am different from them.
- Will I feel pressured to disclose deeply personal matters?
- What if my friends or family members ask me about what I share in my group?
- I fear being hurt.
- What if the group attacks me?
- What if I feel like my cultural values are not being respected or understood?
- What if I find out things about myself that I can't cope with?
- I'm afraid I'll change and that those I'm close to won't like my changes.
- I'm afraid that I might break down and cry.

In the initial stage, we begin by asking group members to identify their fears and begin to explore them. It sometimes helps in building a trusting atmosphere to ask people to split up into pairs and then to join to make groups of four. In this way members can choose others with whom to share their expectations, get acquainted, and talk about their fears or reservations. Talking with one other person, and then merging with others, is far less threatening to most participants than

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talking to the entire group. This subgroup approach is an excellent icebreaker, and when the entire group gets together again, there is generally a greater willingness to interact.

Usually group members are reserved in the beginning, but some group members may jump in full force without much testing of the waters. This is another way in which anxiety can manifest itself, and sometimes these members need the leader's help in slowing down and not sharing too much too quickly.

Learning in Action

Wall of Fears

Before the group session, the group leader writes each of the following fears and concerns on separate pieces of paper and posts them on the wall in different places around the room:

"I'm afraid/concerned I won't fit in."

"I'm afraid/concerned I won't be understood."

"I'm afraid/concerned about being judged."

"I'm afraid/concerned about people knowing my secrets."

"I'm afraid/concerned I won't get anything out of this group."

"I'm afraid/concerned that I will be too much for people."

"I'm afraid/concerned that the leaders won't know how to help me."

"My fear/concern is . . ."

Ask members to stand by the "fear" that most resonates with them. Once all members have chosen their spot, ask them to stay there and silently look around the room at where others are standing. Then ask members the following discussion questions.

Discussion Questions

- Will you share with the group the fear you chose and why?
- Were you surprised by some of the places other members stood? Did it match your initial impression of them?
- In what ways do you need to challenge yourself in this group if you choose to move through your fear or concern?
- How can the group and the leader help you to move through your fear or concern?

Hidden Agendas

A common form of resistance in groups relates to the presence of an unidentified or **hidden agenda**—an issue that is not openly acknowledged and discussed and may not even be in the members' conscious awareness. If encouragement to face these issues is lacking, the group process gets bogged down because the norm of being closed, cautious, and defensive replaces the norm of being open. When there are unspoken reactions (by one member, several members, or the entire group), a common set of features emerges: trust is low, interpersonal tensions emerge, people are guarded and unwilling to take risks, the leader seems to be working harder than the members, and there is a vague feeling that something just does not make sense.

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Consider these scenarios. In one group a member said, "There's someone in this room I don't like." The entire group was affected by this comment, and several members later disclosed that they had wondered if they were the disliked person. It was not until the member was willing to deal directly with the conflict he was having with another participant that the atmosphere in the room cleared up. In another group, composed of adolescents, many members displayed a great unwillingness to talk. The hidden agenda was the concern over rumors that some gossiping was taking place. Members who were concerned about confidentiality were reluctant to express their feelings because of the fear of repercussions.

A group made up mostly of members from a fundamentalist religious background also suffered from a hidden agenda. Some of the members eventually disclosed that their hesitation to get involved in the group was out of fear that they, as well as their religion, would be unfavorably judged if they revealed any struggles regarding their faith. They were anxious about the reactions of both those members who shared their faith as well as those who did not. Only after addressing their fears of being judged was the group able to move forward.

In another group, one member (Roger) had expressed considerable emotion during a session, which inhibited the trust level in the group in the following session. Although many members seemed involved in this member's work, at the next session there was a mood of quietness in the group. With the prodding of the group leader, members eventually revealed what was behind their hesitation to speak up. Some had been frightened by the intensity of Roger's feelings and were not sure what they should do about the reactions they had. Others who had been deeply touched wanted to get involved by discussing their own problems, but they didn't want to interrupt Roger's continued work. Some who were moved personally were afraid to acknowledge this for fear that they might "lose control" as Roger had. Other members were angry because they felt Roger had been "left hanging"; they couldn't see what good it had done for him to get so worked up and then not get an answer to his problem. Still others eventually confessed that they were burdening themselves with "performance anxiety." They thought they would have to display a great deal of emotional intensity to be accepted in the group. If they did not cry, they were afraid others might perceive them as being superficial.

In our training and supervision workshops, we have sometimes made an erroneous assumption that all the participants are there voluntarily. In several cases in various agencies, reluctant behavior was initially high because some members were pressured by their superiors to attend. Workshop participants often wondered how information they revealed about themselves would be used outside of the group. This was a critical part of the informed consent process. We encouraged them to raise any questions they had about the workshop and also to express any of their concerns or grievances. Even though we were not able to remove the pressure they felt over having to attend, our willingness to listen to and respect what they had to say did help them overcome their reluctance to participate.

All of these reactions are material for possible productive interaction if group members are willing to bring them up. By fully expressing and exploring such reactions, members genuinely develop the basis of trust. On the other hand, if members stifle their reactions, the group loses its vitality. Group issues that do not

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get talked about almost always develop into a hidden agenda that immobilizes the individuals and shatters trust in the group.

It is generally a good idea to begin working with the reluctant behavior in a group. Reluctance to speak out may function as a healthy boundary rather than being an expression of resistance. For example, a person who has been abused may not be so quick to trust. If leaders go where the energy is and facilitate its direct expression, they are less likely to get stuck. The screening processes we do prior to beginning a group helps us learn the history of group members, which enables us to better understand some of their reactions during the group process.

As a group leader, you cannot burden yourself with knowing all of the potential hidden agendas present in a group, but you can anticipate possible hidden agendas that may operate given the nature of a specific group. Reflect on the existence of such agendas and find ways to assist members to identify and articulate their concerns. Once group members recognize that some dynamics are affecting the group process, the hidden agenda is less likely to sabotage the group process. The members can then be challenged to decide how they will deal with their concerns.

Groups do not progress unless hidden agendas are uncovered and discussed.

Groups do not progress unless hidden agendas are uncovered and discussed. This process often requires patience from the leader and a willingness to continually check with members to find out if they are saying what they need to say. What bogs down groups is not so much what people *are* saying but what they *are not* saying. Although it is generally not comfortable for leaders to deal with these undercurrents, respectfully yet firmly challenging members to express persistent thoughts and feelings about what is emerging in the group is extremely valuable.

One of the best ways to facilitate the exploration of a potential hidden agenda in a group is for you to reflect on your own experience as a member of a group. Have you been in a group where a hidden agenda was present? If so, how did this affect you? Were you inclined to talk about how you were being affected by the presence of a hidden agenda? What may have inhibited you or helped you to feel empowered to talk about this in your group? How can you apply your experience as a group member to groups you will be facilitating?

Address Conflict Early

LO2

Conflict can emerge in any stage of group work, although it is most common later during the transition stage. Conflict that arises early in a group must be adequately dealt with, or it is likely to inhibit the cohesion of the group. When conflict first occurs, members are keenly aware of and observe a leader's actions. The leader must respond to and, whenever possible, facilitate a resolution of the conflict so the group can progress.

Let's examine a conflict that might surface during the first group session:

Leader: What are you aware of as you look around the room?

Elijah: I need to be in a group with strong men, and I don't think this is the right group for me.

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Travis: That's the most homophobic remark! Just because I'm gay you think I'm not a strong man.

Elijah: That's not what I mean. You're taking it the wrong way.

Travis: I know exactly what you meant.

Leader: Travis, please say more about your reactions to Elijah and how his comment affected you.

This interaction immediately raised the tension in the room. Such comments can trigger old wounds, as well as open fresh wounds, in some members. It introduces a conflict as well as a cultural issue that needs to be worked through and attended to so the group will be safe for everyone. The leader could work with this in a variety of ways. One is to have Elijah talk more about what it means for him to be with "strong men." How is this significant in his life, and what is its significance right now? How does he see himself on the strong–weak continuum? The leader could ask Travis, as well as other members, if and how they were affected by Elijah's remark. The male members of the group are likely to have some reactions, and Elijah and other group members need to hear this. A goal of the leader might be to explore the transference reactions that were triggered as a result of Elijah's comment. The other goal is to help Elijah see how his comment may have been offensive to some and triggered some vulnerabilities in certain members who have been subjected to homophobic remarks.

Because this conflict arose during the early stage of the group, it is critical that the leader teach the norm of appropriate and effective confrontation. If the matter is bypassed, ignored, or smoothed over by the leader's lack of intervention, members are likely to feel unsafe and to behave cautiously. This unaddressed conflict can easily negatively affect the energy in the room and impede the group's progress.

Self-Focus Versus Focus on Others

A characteristic of many members in beginning groups is the tendency to talk about others and to focus on people and situations outside of the group. Individuals who talk excessively may do so for any of the following reasons:

- They are disconnected from their feelings, and staying on an intellectual level helps them to avoid feelings.
- They may have difficulty connecting with others or getting support from them, and talking makes them less anxious.
- They may be testing the leader and the members to assess how they will respond to them.
- They may come from a culture in which "small talk" is a way to connect and gain trust.

Some participants may engage in storytelling, believing they are really working, when in fact they are avoiding addressing and dealing with their own feelings. They may talk about life situations, but they have a tendency to focus on what other people do to cause them difficulties. Skilled group leaders help such members examine their own reactions to others.

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During the initial phase of a group, the leader's primary task is to get group members to focus on themselves. Of course, trust is a prerequisite for this openness. When members focus on others as a way to avoid self-exploration, our leadership task is to enable them to focus on their own reactions. We might say, "I'm aware that you're talking a lot about several important people in your life. They're not here, and we won't be able to work with them. But we are able to work with your feelings and reactions toward them and how their behavior affects you." An awareness of proper timing is essential. The readiness of a client to accept certain interpretations or observations must be considered. We must be skilled not only in helping people recognize that their focus on others can be defensive, but also in encouraging them to express their feelings. Not all such behavior is defensive; it may be culturally appropriate for some members to avoid focusing on themselves. Only by exploring the members' behavior can you get a sense of the meaning underlying the focus on others.

Here-and-Now Focus Versus There-and-Then Focus

Some groups have a primary focus on what is occurring right now in the room. The predominant theme these groups explore is present member–member interactions, and the material for discussion emerges from these encounters. Other groups focus largely on outside problems that members bring to the session or deal with specified topics for exploration. The practitioner's theoretical orientation influences whether the focus is on what is presently happening within the group or on past events outside of the group. As you saw in Chapter 4, the experiential and relationship-oriented approaches emphasize the here and now, the cognitive behavioral approaches are mainly concerned with a present-centered focus, and the psychodynamic approaches consider a there-and-then focus. Our groups combine both a here-and-now and a there-and-then focus. Members are often not ready to deal with significant issues pertaining to their lives away from the group until they first deal with their reactions to one another in the room. To meaningfully explore personal problems, members must first feel safe and trusting.

During the initial sessions, we ask members to make connections between personal problems they are facing in their world and their experience in the group. If a member discloses that she feels isolated in her life, for instance, we ask her to be aware of how she may be isolating herself in the group setting. If another member shares how he overextends himself in his life and rarely attends to himself because of his concern for others, we would ask him how this might become an issue for him in this group. If a member states that she feels like an outsider, we tend to ask if she often feels this way in her daily life. These members may isolate, overextend themselves, and feel like outsiders in the group sessions, and dealing with these here-and-now occurrences can serve as a springboard for exploring deeper personal concerns. Staying focused with what is presently happening within the group can help members identify specific aspects of their behavior they want to change.

Paying attention to here-and-now interactions is of the utmost value, for the way members behave in the present context of the group is reflective of how they interact with others outside the group. The opportunities for interpersonal

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learning that groups provide are unique. One of the best ways to learn more about members' interpersonal style is by paying attention to their behavior in the group setting. Members learn a great deal about how they function interpersonally in their world by becoming aware of their patterns in the group sessions.

Interventions that direct members to gain awareness of what they are experiencing in the here and now tend to intensify the emotional quality of interactions. Rather than having members talk about their problems in a reporting fashion, we consistently encourage members to note what it is that they are experiencing presently. If members have a problem in daily life that they want to explore, we typically intervene by helping them bring this concern into the present group context. Although group participants often have a self-protective tendency to avoid the here and now, one of the main tasks of the group facilitator is to consistently assist members in directing their attention to what they are thinking, feeling, and doing in the moment. The more members are able to immerse themselves in the here and now, the greater chance they have to enhance the quality of their interpersonal relationships in everyday life.

There are both strengths and limitations in working from a here-and-now perspective. By focusing on what is happening in the room, we are able to help members work through their personal concerns. Here-and-now communication also helps to move the group process along and gives members a chance to express what they are experiencing. However, if someone is talking about an important personal matter such as past spousal abuse or another trauma and we try to direct the member toward the here and now too quickly, we may be interfering with important grief work that needs to be done. In addition, if we raise questions or make interventions in an untimely way, we may risk insulting or invalidating the member's experience. This is especially true with racial issues. If, for example, we are too quick to confront a person of color who is talking about not trusting White people because of past experiences, we may risk devaluing this member's past life experiences in an effort to help her gain a new perspective. In general, it is most helpful to validate a member's experience and to have the person discuss the impact of those experiences before making interventions that might leave the member feeling discounted or misunderstood. Sometimes our efforts to be culturally responsive can leave us feeling paralyzed. We cannot fully anticipate the impact of our interventions, so it is important to check in with members and ask how they are doing with us and with the interventions we make. When we ask members questions, we must be open to hearing their answers. Respond respectfully and integrate their feedback into your practice.

Trust Versus Mistrust

If a basic sense of trust is not established at the outset of a group, problems are likely to arise later. Signs of developing trust include members expressing feelings without fear of censure; members being willing to decide for themselves specific goals and personal areas to explore; members focusing on themselves, not on others; and members being willing to risk disclosing personal aspects of themselves. Trust entails a sense of safety, but it does not necessarily entail being comfortable. Members often say that they are uncomfortable in a group session.

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Trust entails a sense of safety, but it does not necessarily entail being comfortable.

It is important to teach members that they are not apt to feel comfortable when they are talking about matters of significance. We hope they will be willing to endure the anxiety and discomfort associated with taking risks.

In contrast, a lack of trust is indicated by an undercurrent of anger and suspicion in the group and members being unwilling to talk about these feelings. Other manifestations of lack of trust are participants' taking refuge in being abstract or overly intellectual and being vague about what they expect from the therapeutic group. Before a climate of trust is established, people tend to wait for the leader to decide for them what they need to examine. Any disclosures made tend to be superficial and rehearsed, and risk-taking is at a low level. Members are more likely to push themselves when they perceive the group as being a safe place to challenge themselves. It is through taking risks that safety is created.

LO3

Creating Trust: Leader and Member Roles

The Importance of Modeling

Our success in creating a climate of trust within a group has much to do with how well we have prepared both the members and ourselves. As described in Chapter 4, presence on the part of the leader is the cornerstone of most of the experiential and relationship-oriented approaches to group counseling. To be an effective leader, we must be psychologically present in the group and be genuine. In behavior therapy, leader modeling is viewed as basic to establishing trust within a group. We can facilitate the group process by sharing our own expectations for the group during the initial sessions and by modeling interpersonal honesty, respect, and spontaneity.

If we have given careful thought to why we are organizing the group, what we hope to accomplish, and how we will go about meeting our objectives, the chances are greatly increased that we will inspire confidence. The members will see our willingness to think about the group as a sign that we care about them. Furthermore, if we have done an adequate job with the pregroup issues—informing members of their rights and responsibilities, giving some time to teaching the group process, exploring the congruence between the cultural values of members and what they are expected to do, and preparing the members for a successful experience—the members will realize that we are taking our work seriously and that we are interested in their welfare.

Regardless of a leader's theoretical orientation, establishing trust is a central task for the initial stage of a group. It is not possible to overemphasize the significance of the leader's modeling and the attitudes expressed through the leader's behavior in these early sessions. Reflecting on your role as a leader, ask yourself:

- How competent do I feel in leading or coleading this particular group?
- How confident am I that I can establish trust with the group and between group members?

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The person you are and, especially, how you behave in the sessions are crucial factors in building a trusting community. (Refer to our discussion of the personal characteristics of the effective leader in Chapter 2. Also see the discussion of the leader as a person in the experiential and relationship-oriented approaches in Chapter 4.)

If we trust in the group process and have faith in the members' capacity to make significant changes in themselves, they are likely to see value in their group as a pathway to personal growth. If we listen nondefensively and respectfully and convey that we value members' subjective experience, they are likely to see the power in active listening. If we are genuinely willing to engage in appropriate self-disclosure, we will foster honesty and disclosure among the members. If we are truly able to accept others for who they are and avoid imposing our values on them, our members will learn valuable lessons about accepting people's rights to differ and to be themselves. In short, what you model through what you do in the group is one of the most powerful ways of teaching members how to relate to one another constructively and deeply.

Students in my (Cindy's) classes tell me that they value the personal experiences I share and that my doing so helps them to relate to me, which encourages them to become more open. Although my self-disclosures are often spontaneous, they are purposeful and meant to help facilitate the work of group members. For example, I might talk about a relationship difficulty I have had to help a member who is feeling shame about a similar issue. Sometimes my aim in disclosing is to normalize a member's experience and to promote disclosure among the members, which is likely to happen if they feel less alone in their experience. Leaders need to be careful in self-disclosing so that they do not interfere with the work of group members. However, appropriate self-disclosure can enhance group trust and promote universality.

If you are coleading a group, you and your colleague have ample opportunities to model a behavioral style that will promote trust. If the two of you function harmoniously with a spontaneous give and take, for example, members will feel more trusting in your presence. If your relationship with your coleader is characterized by respect, authenticity, sensitivity, and directness, the members will learn about the value of such attitudes and behaviors. Furthermore, the way the two of you interact with the members contributes to or detracts from the level of trust. If one coleader's typical manner of speaking with members is sharp, short, and sarcastic, for example, members are likely to quickly pick up this leader's lack of respect for them and tend to become closed or defensive. Therefore, it is wise for coleaders to examine each other's style of interacting and to talk about this when they meet privately outside of the group.

It is a mistake to assume that as a leader or a coleader you have sole responsibility for the development and maintenance of trust. The level of trust is engendered by your attitudes and actions, yet it also depends to a large degree on the level of investment of the members. If members want very little for themselves, if they are unwilling to share enough of themselves so that they can be known, if they simply wait passively for you to "make trust happen," and if they are unwilling to take risks in the sessions, trust will be slow to develop. The tone set

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by your leadership will influence members' willingness to disclose themselves and to begin taking those steps necessary to establish trust.

For a good example of how a group practitioner lays a foundation of trust-building during the initial phase of a group, see the women's support group for survivors of incest in a community agency in Chapter 11. The therapist believes that what takes place during the early stage of a group is crucial to what will occur later in the group. At the first group meeting, she emphasizes the importance of regular attendance, being prompt, confidentiality, the limitations of time, and bringing any unresolved issues back to the group rather than dealing with them outside of the group. Bonding begins quickly as members express empathy with one another over the difficulty of sharing the incest issue. As members realize that they have a common experience, they share at a deeper level and find the support available in the group to be very meaningful. By sharing the incest experience, members free themselves to deal with the effects the incest continues to have on their lives.

The issue of trust is never settled once and for all; it will continue to manifest itself in different forms throughout the life of the group. Ongoing attention to trust issues is necessary for members to continue to trust one another. Members need to learn that the more threatening the material explored becomes, the more the issue of trust becomes central. It is essential that the members demonstrate a willingness to acknowledge their lack of trust, and a good place to begin is by talking about what makes it difficult for them to trust. Certainly the delicate nature of trust is a focal point for the early stage of any group.

Learning in Action

Developing Trust

If you were to think of building trust as occurring in stages, how might you describe your own process for cultivating trust in a group? Think of your willingness to trust others as well as your ability to be a trustworthy member or participant.

Stage 1: Checking Out the Scene

- How do you go about observing others? Do you process internally? Are you quiet or talkative? Do you form opinions of others quickly? Are you open-minded, guarded, or judgmental?
- What do your behaviors and interactions look like when you are "checking out the scene"?

Stage 2: Experimenting With Trust

- How do you test others to see if they are trustworthy? Do you let others risk first, or do you take the first step? Do you expect others to be trustworthy or not? How do you show others that you can be trusted?
- What do your behaviors and interactions look like when you are experimenting with trust?

Stage 3: Trusting and Being Trustworthy

- Once you have decided that trust has been established, do you still proceed with caution or open up easily? Do you find it easier to be trusted or to trust others?
- What do your behaviors and interactions look like when you are trusting others and being trustworthy?

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Stage 4: Surviving Breaches in Trust

- If someone breaks your trust, what impact does this have on you? Are you able to easily forgive? Does it permanently damage the relationship? How does a person go about rebuilding trust with you once it has been broken?
- What feelings are evoked within you when trust is broken? What do your behaviors and interactions look like when trust has been breached in a relationship?

Attitudes and Actions Leading to Trust

Certain attitudes and actions of leaders enhance the level of trust in a group. Some of these factors include attending and listening, understanding both verbal and nonverbal behavior, empathy, genuineness, self-disclosure, respect, and caring confrontation. These attitudes on the part of the group leader are given prominence in the person-centered approach to group counseling (see Chapter 4).

Attending and Listening Careful attending to the verbal and nonverbal messages of others is necessary for trust to occur. If genuine listening and understanding are absent, there is no basis for connection between members. If members feel that they are being heard and deeply understood, they are more likely to trust that others care about them too.

If genuine listening and understanding are absent, there is no basis for connection between members.

Both leaders and members may demonstrate a lack of attending in different ways. Here are some of the most common ones: (1) not listening to the speaker because you are thinking of what to say next, (2) asking many closed questions that probe for irrelevant and detailed information, (3) doing too much talking and not enough listening, (4) giving advice too quickly instead of encouraging the speaker to explore a struggle, (5) paying attention only to what people say explicitly and thus missing what they express nonverbally, (6) engaging in selective listening (hearing only what you want to hear), and (7) failing to ask people to give voice to what their body is experiencing.

Group members do not always possess good listening skills, nor do they always respond effectively to what they perceive. Therefore, teaching basic listening and responding skills is a major part of the trust process. If members do not feel listened to, they are not likely to get very deep or personal.

Understanding Nonverbal Behavior Inexperienced group workers frequently make the error of focusing exclusively on what members are saying and miss the more subtle nonverbal messages. People often express themselves more honestly nonverbally than they do verbally. Detecting discrepancies between verbal and nonverbal behavior is an art to be learned. Examples of clients displaying these discrepancies include a member who is talking about a painful experience while smiling; a member who speaks very softly and proclaims that nobody listens to him; a client who is verbally expressing positive feelings yet is very constricted physically; a person who says that she really wants to work and to have group time but consistently waits until the end of a session before bringing up her concerns; a participant who claims that she feels comfortable in the group and really

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likes the members yet sits with her arms crossed tightly and looks at the floor; and a member who displays facial expressions and gestures but denies having any reactions.

Although these gestures may seem fairly easy to interpret, leaders should not too quickly offer an interpretation. For example, in a group we were coleading, a male group member would often clear his throat before speaking about emotional topics. We wondered if this was a way for him to distance himself emotionally from what he was about to express. When we brought the mannerism to his attention, his initial response was to dismiss it as "just a bad habit." We continued to draw his attention to the times when he would clear his throat, and he eventually connected this mannerism to his own discomfort with feeling and showing emotion. This led him to other realizations about how he held back his feelings. If we had been too quick to make an interpretation or to back off from his initial defensiveness, he may not have acquired these insights. Coincidentally, when this member was able to more openly share his feelings, this habit seemed to disappear.

Although you may think you have a clear idea of what a nonverbal behavior means, it is a good idea to file away some of your impressions and draw on them as the group unfolds and as a pattern of behavior becomes manifest. When you do explore nonverbal behavior with a member, it is best to describe the behavior. For example, "I notice that you're smiling, yet you're talking about painful memories, and there are tears in your eyes. Are you aware of that?" When you describe behavior, you are less likely to analyze. After describing what you are seeing, invite the participant to offer the meaning of the nonverbal behavior. At times you may misunderstand nonverbal information and even label it as resistance. The nonverbal behavior may well be a manifestation of a cultural injunction. For example, a leader is role playing Javier's father and asks Javier to make eye contact with him as he is talking. In spite of many invitations, Javier continues to look at the floor as he talks to his symbolic father. The leader is unaware that Javier would have felt disrespectful if he looked directly at his father or another authority figure. This is something that can be explored if the leader respectfully listens to Javier and strives to understand the meaning of his behavior.

Another avenue for helping clients to give full expression to their feelings is by asking clients to pay attention to what they are experiencing physically. For example, if you have a client who is talking a lot, but seems emotionally detached from the content, you could ask her what she is most aware of in her body at that moment. She may respond by saying, "I feel heat in my chest area." This might open up an entirely new way for you to help her connect to her feelings and to express feelings in a more integrated and holistic manner.

In summary, it is essential that we avoid making assumptions and interpretations about what members are experiencing and, instead, assist members to recognize and explore the possible meanings of their nonverbal behavior and their bodily experience. If we misread or ignore nonverbal messages or insensitively confront certain behavior, the level of trust in the group will suffer. When we point out what we are observing, we do so respectfully, giving members the opportunity to explore what they are experiencing.

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Empathy Empathy is the ability to tune in to what others are subjectively experiencing and to see the world through their eyes. Empathy is not the same thing as sympathy, which entails providing comfort to others. When people experience empathic understanding without critical judgment, they are more likely to reveal their deeper concerns because they believe others understand and accept them as they are. This kind of nonjudgmental understanding is vital to establishing trust.

One of our leadership functions is to help members develop greater empathy by pointing out behaviors that block this understanding. Examples of these counterproductive behaviors include responding to others with pat statements, not responding to others at all, questioning inappropriately, telling others how they should be, responding with critical judgments, or being defensive.

Empathy is an avenue of demonstrating support. For example, Judy benefits when others are able to understand her. If she talks about going through an extremely painful divorce, Clyde can let her know the ways in which he identifies with and understands her pain. Though their circumstances are different, he empathizes with her pain and is willing to share with her his feelings of rejection and abandonment when his wife left him. What helps Judy is Clyde's willingness to tell her about his struggles rather than providing her with quick answers. Instead of telling her what he did or offering her reassurance, he helps her most by sharing his struggles and pain with her.

Genuineness Genuineness implies congruence between a person's inner experience and what he or she projects externally. Applied to our role as a leader, genuineness means that we do not pretend to be accepting when internally we are not feeling accepting, we do not rely on behaviors that are aimed at winning approval, and we avoid hiding behind our professional role. Through our own authenticity, we offer a model that inspires members to be real in their interactions.

Consider a couple of examples in which you might be challenged to provide authentic responses rather than expected ones. A member who is new to your group might spontaneously ask you, "What do you think of me?" You could politely respond with, "I think you're a very nice person." Here is a more honest response: "I don't know you well enough to have strong reactions to you. As I get to know you better, I'll share my perceptions with you." You might want to ask this person what prompted her question and discover that she is intimidated by your position in the group and needs quick reassurance. By helping her identify the reason for her question, you can help her be more authentic with you. In another case, in the middle of a conflict a member says to you, "Oh, give me a hug; I don't like this tension between us." Chances are that you don't really feel like hugging him at this moment. It is nevertheless important that you give an honest reply to his request. You could say, "I'm struggling with you right now, and I want to continue working this through. If I were to hug you right now, it would not feel consistent with what I'm experiencing with you. However, that doesn't mean that I won't want to hug you later."

Self-Disclosure Our authenticity can sometimes be expressed in appropriate self-disclosure. We can invite members to make themselves known by revealing our own thoughts and feelings related to what is going on within the group. If we avoid hiding, we will encourage the rest of the group to be open about their

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concerns. Sometimes group participants will challenge us by saying, "We tell you all of our problems, but we don't know any of yours." We could surrender to this pressure to prove that we are "genuine" and disclose a personal problem, but this forced disclosure may not be in the best interests of the group. A more appropriate response might be: "Yes, in this group, due to my role, I'm likely to learn more about the nature of your problems than you will learn about my personal concerns, but this doesn't mean that I don't have difficulties in my life. If you and I were members in another group, I expect that you'd learn more about me. While I'm not likely to bring my outside problems into this group, I'm very willing to let you know how I'm being affected in these sessions and also to reveal my reactions to you."

Decisions about self-disclosure are culture-bound and value laden. In some cases, the willingness of a leader to engage in self-disclosure is both culturally appropriate and a way to create trust. For some members it would seem unnatural not to know anything personal about the leader, whereas other members may be extremely uncomfortable knowing personal information about the leader. It is important to discuss the difference in needs that the group members may have and how culture might be a large part of the members' expectations of the leader. The goal is to understand what the member wants from the leader and to decide how this might be accomplished. For example, when I (Cindy) was working with refugees from Sudan, I was struck by how important it was to share some information about my family. In Sudanese culture it was unheard of to discuss personal topics with someone if they did not know something about the family and where he or she came from. Sharing this information is not typical, but I felt it was necessary and appropriate to do so with the young men from Sudan so they could open up about their experiences in the civil war and as refugees. If I had maintained a stance of "no personal self-disclosure," I doubt that a trusting bond would have developed between us.

Group members may ask personal questions of leaders for a variety of reasons. Clinicians need to be aware of the limits of their sharing both for their own and their members' benefit. Many therapists will answer personal questions (about their age, significant relationships, past experiences) and then question the member about what it was like to hear the response. Self-disclosure can be useful when it is intentional and keeps the focus of attention on the group members rather than on the leader.

Respect Respect is shown by what the leader and the members actually do, not simply by what they say. Attitudes and actions that demonstrate respect include avoiding critical judgments, avoiding labeling, looking beyond self-imposed or other-imposed labels, expressing warmth and support that is honestly felt, being genuine and risking, and recognizing the rights of others to be different. For example, if a member discloses his strong sense of filial piety (an accepted norm in his culture), others in the group demonstrate respect when they strive to understand rather than judge his loyalty and need to please his parents. If people receive this type of respect, they are supported in their attempts to talk about themselves in open and meaningful ways.

Nina may express her fear of being judged by others and talk about how she is reluctant to speak because of this fear of criticism. Members are not offering her

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respect if they too quickly reassure her that they like her just as she is and that they would not judge her. By encouraging Nina to explore where in her life she feels judged by others, she may discover that her feelings of being judged reside within her and that she projects them onto others. Although group members could reassure Nina, as soon as she is away from the group her internal judge would take over again. It would be more helpful to encourage her to explore her fear of being judged, both in past situations and in the group.

Caring Confrontation The way in which confrontations are handled can either build or inhibit the development of trust in a group. A confrontation can be an act of caring that takes the form of an invitation for members to examine some discrepancy between what they are saying and what they are doing or between what they are saying and some nonverbal cues they are manifesting. We can teach members directness coupled with sensitivity, which results in their seeing that confrontation can be done in a caring yet honest manner. Some members may have difficulty with even the most caring confrontation and may interpret it as a personal attack, although that is far from what was intended. We make it a practice to check in with members to see how they are receiving the confrontation and how they are doing with us after we have made the intervention. We do not assume that because a member looks fine on the outside he or she is feeling fine.

When confrontations are made in an abrasive, "hit-and-run" fashion, or if the leader allows verbal abuse, trust is greatly inhibited. Attacking comments or aggressive confrontations close people up by making them defensive. Caring confrontations help members learn to express even negative reactions in a way that respects those they are confronting. For example, Claire is very willing to speak on everything and constantly brings herself in on others' work. An ineffective confrontation by a group leader is this: "I want you to be quiet and let others in here talk." An effective leader confrontation is this: "Claire, I appreciate your willingness to participate and talk about yourself. However, I'm concerned that I have heard very little from several others in the group, and I want to hear from them too."

Maintaining Trust The attitudes and behaviors described in these sections have an important bearing on the level of trust established within a group. Although trust is the major task to be accomplished at the initial stage of a group's development, it is a mistake to assume that once trust has been established it is ensured for the duration of that group. Trust ebbs and flows, and new levels of trust must be established as the group progresses toward a deeper level of intimacy. A basic sense of safety is essential for the movement of a group beyond the initial stage, but this trust will be tested time and again and take on new facets in later stages.



LO4

Identifying and Clarifying Goals

A major task during the initial stage is for leaders to assist members in identifying and clarifying specific goals that will influence their participation. In the absence of a clear understanding about the purpose of a group and the meaningful goals of members, much needless floundering can occur. Members may have difficulty

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making progress until they know *why* they are in the group and *how* they can make full use of the group to achieve their goals.

The process of setting goals is important both at the beginning of a new group and at intervals as the group evolves and goals are met. Both group goals and individual goals must be established. Examples of general group goals include creating a climate of trust and acceptance, promoting self-disclosure in significant ways, and encouraging the taking of risks. If these goals (and norms, which we discuss later) are not explicitly stated, understood, and accepted by the members early in the group, considerable confusion is likely to occur at a later stage. Some general goals common to most therapeutic groups and some examples of goals for specialized groups are discussed in the following sections.

General Goals for Group Members

Although the members must decide for themselves the specific aims of their group experience, here are some broad goals common to many different types of groups:

- Become aware of one's interpersonal style
- Increase awareness of what prevents intimacy
- Learn how to trust oneself and others
- Become aware of how one's culture affects personal decisions
- Increase self-awareness and thereby increase the possibilities for choice and action
- Discover one's strengths and resources
- Challenge and explore certain early decisions (most likely made during childhood) that may no longer be functional
- Recognize that others have similar problems and feelings
- Clarify values and decide whether and how to modify them
- Become both independent and interdependent
- Find better ways to resolve problems
- Become more open and honest with selected others
- Become sensitive to the needs and feelings of others
- Provide others with helpful feedback

Once members have narrowed down their list of general goals, group leaders have a responsibility to monitor the group's progress toward attainment of these group goals (ASGW, 2008). Our colleague Gerald Monk, a professor at San Diego State University, suggests the following questions to assist clients in identifying their goals for counseling (personal communication, August 20, 2002):

- In what ways might I feel and behave differently if my life were as I want it to be?
- What steps can I take to help bring about these desired changes in my emotions and in my behaviors?
- What internal and external barriers exist that interfere with reaching my goals?
- What support systems can I use in reaching my goals?

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Helping Members Define Personal Goals

Forming clear goals is important regardless of the theory a leader operates from, but this is given particular emphasis in the cognitive behavioral approaches. For instance, in cognitive therapy the leader strives to create a collaborative partnership with group members. In behavioral group therapy, the definition of specific goals is central to both assessment and treatment. (For more discussion of how a leader's theory affects the process of establishing goals, see Chapter 4.)

Regardless of the type of therapeutic group, leaders have the task of helping participants develop concrete goals that will give them direction. Participants are typically able to state only in broad terms what they expect to get from a group. It is critical that members learn how to translate general goals into measurable ones. For example, one member's broad goal may be, "I want to love myself more." The member's concrete goal might be, "I will do the things that bring me joy such as exercise, listening to music, spending time with friends, and journaling." Another member, Ebony, may want to learn to "relate to others better." The leader's questions should help her become more specific about relationship goals. With whom is she having difficulties? If the answer is her parents, then what specifically is causing her problems with them? How is she affected by these problems? How does she want to be different with her parents? With all this information, the leader has a clearer idea of how to proceed with this member.

Here are some examples of how leaders can intervene to help different members make a vague goal more specific:

Member A: I want to get in touch with my feelings.

Leader: What kind of feelings are you having difficulty with?

Member B: I want to work on my anger.

Leader: With whom in your life are you angry? What is it about the way you express your anger that you dislike? What do you most want to say to these people you are angry with?

Member C: I have very low self-esteem.

Leader: List some of the ways in which you devalue yourself.

Member D: I have trouble with intimacy.

Leader: Who in your life are you having trouble getting close to, and what might you be doing to prevent the intimacy you want?

Member E: I don't want to feel marginalized.

Leader: How do you experience being marginalized, and with whom? Is feeling marginalized an issue for you in this group?

Defining personal goals is an ongoing process, not something that is done once and for all. Throughout the course of a group, it is important to help members assess the degree to which their personal goals are being met and, if appropriate, to help them revise their goals. As members gain more experience, they are in a better position to know what they want from a group, and they also come to recognize additional goals that can guide their participation. Their involvement in the work of other members can act as a catalyst in getting them to think about ways in which they can profit from the group experience.

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Establishing a contract is one excellent way for members to clarify and attain their personal goals. Basically, a contract is a statement by participants of what problems they want to explore and what behaviors they are willing to change. In the contract method, group members assume an active and responsible stance. Contracts can be open-ended so that they can be modified or replaced as appropriate. Contracts can be useful for most of the groups discussed in this book, but they are most often used by cognitive behavioral group practitioners.

Contracts and homework assignments can be combined fruitfully. In Ebony's case, a beginning contract could commit her to observe and write down each time she experiences difficulties with her parents. If she discovers that she usually walks away in times of conflict with them, she might pledge in a follow-up contract to stay in one of these situations rather than avoid the conflict.

LO5

Group Process Concepts at the Initial Stage

The group process, as we have said, involves the stages groups tend to go through, each characterized by certain feelings and behaviors. Initially, as the members get to know one another, there is a feeling of anxiety. Each typically waits for someone else to begin. Tension and conflict may build up. If things go well, however, the members learn to trust one another and the leader, and they begin to openly express feelings, thoughts, and reactions. Thus, included under the rubric **group process** are activities such as establishing norms and group cohesion, learning to work cooperatively, establishing ways of solving problems, and learning to express conflict openly. Two group process concepts especially important during the initial stage are group norms and group cohesion.

Group Norms

Group norms are the shared beliefs about expected behaviors aimed at making groups function effectively. It is helpful to have clearly-stated and well-defined expectations for group members. Norms and procedures that will help the group attain its goals can be developed during the early stage. Norms can be explicitly stated, but many groups also have implicit (or unspoken) norms.

Implicit norms may develop because of preconceived ideas about what takes place in a group. Members may assume, for example, that a group is a place where everything must be said, with no regard for privacy. Unless the leader calls attention to the possibility that members can be self-disclosing and still retain a measure of privacy, members may misinterpret the norm of openness and honesty as a policy of complete candor, with no privacy. Another example of an implicit norm is pressure to experience catharsis and crying. In most of our intensive therapeutic groups, there is a fair amount of crying and expression of pent-up feelings. We need to be careful to avoid reinforcing emotional expression that suggests that "real work" consists of catharsis. Many individuals engage in significant self-exploration with little, if any, emotional catharsis. Members can learn from cognitive and behavioral exploration as well as from emotional expression and exploration.

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Implicit norms may develop because of modeling by the leader. If a leader uses hostile and abrasive language, members are more likely to adopt this pattern of speech in their group interactions, even though the leader has never encouraged people to talk in such a manner. Implicit norms do affect the group, either positively or negatively. Norms are less likely to have a negative impact if they are made explicit.

Here are some **explicit norms**, or standards of behavior, that are common in many groups:

- Members are expected to attend regularly and to show up on time. When they attend sessions only sporadically, the entire group suffers. Members who regularly attend may have reactions to the lack of commitment of those who miss sessions.
- Members are encouraged to be personal and share meaningful aspects of themselves, communicating directly with others in the group and, in general, being active participants.
- Members are expected to give feedback to one another. They can evaluate the effects of their behavior on others only if the others are willing to say how they have been affected. It is important for members not to withhold their perceptions and reactions but, rather, to let others know what they perceive.
- Members are encouraged to focus on here-and-now interactions within the group. Members focus on being immediate by expressing and exploring conflicts within the group. Immediacy is called for when there are unexpressed thoughts and feelings about what is happening in a session, particularly if these reactions will have a detrimental effect on the group process. Thus, one of your leadership functions is to ask questions such as these: "What is it like to be in this group now?" "With whom do you identify in here?" "What are some of the things that you might be rehearsing to yourself silently?" "Who are you most aware of in this room?" You can also guide members into the here and now by asking them to share what they think and feel about what is going on in the group moment by moment.
- Members are expected to bring into the group sessions personal problems and concerns that they are willing to discuss. They can be expected to spend some time before the sessions thinking about the matters they want to work on. This is an area in which unspoken norms frequently function. In some groups, for example, participants may get the idea that they are not good group members unless they bring personal issues from everyday life to work on during the sessions. Members may get the impression that it is not acceptable to talk about here-and-now matters within the group itself and that they should work on outside problems exclusively.
- Members are encouraged to provide therapeutic support. Ideally, this support facilitates both an individual's work and the group process rather than distracting members from self-exploration. But some leaders can implicitly "teach" being overly supportive or, by their modeling, can demonstrate a type of support that has the effect of short-circuiting painful experiences that a member is attempting to work through. Leaders who are uncomfortable with intense emotions (such as anger or the pain associated with past memories) can collude with members by fostering a pseudosupportive climate that

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prevents members from fully experiencing and expressing intense feelings of any kind. Some groups are so supportive that challenge and confrontation are ruled out. An implicit norm in this kind of group results in expressing only positive and favorable reactions.

- The other side of the norm of support is providing members with encouragement to look at themselves. Members need to learn how to confront others without arousing defensiveness. Early in our groups, for example, we establish a norm that it is not acceptable to dismiss another in a judgmental and labeling way, such as by saying, "You are too judgmental." Instead, we teach members to directly and sensitively express the anger they are feeling, avoid name-calling, and avoid pronouncing judgments. Members are asked to express the source of their anger, including what led up to their feelings. For example, if Ann says to Rudy, "You're self-centered and uncaring," the leader can ask Ann to let Rudy know how she has been affected by him and by what she perceives as his uncaring behavior. Ann can also be encouraged to express the stored-up reactions that led her to judge him. In contrast, if leaders model harsh confrontations, members soon pick up the unexpressed norm that the appropriate way to relate to others in this group is by attacking them.
- Groups can operate under either a norm of exploring personal problems or a norm of problem solving. In some groups, for example, as soon as members bring up situations they would like to understand better, they may quickly be given suggestions about how to "solve" these problems. The fact of the matter is that solutions are often not possible, and what members most need is an opportunity to talk. Of course, problem-solving strategies are of use in teaching members new ways of coping with their difficulties. But it is important that clients have an opportunity to explore their concerns before suggested solutions are presented. Ideally, this exploration will enable members to begin to see a range of possibilities open to them and a direction they might pursue in finding their own answers. It is generally more useful for clients to arrive at their own solutions than to follow the advice of others.
- Members can be taught the norm of listening without thinking of a quick rebuttal and without becoming overly defensive. Although we do not expect people to merely accept all the feedback they receive, we do ask them to really hear what others are saying to them and to seriously consider these messages—particularly ones that are repeated consistently.

Group norms need to be followed throughout the life of a group. Many groups become bogged down because members are unsure of what is expected of them or of the norms of the group. For instance, a member may want to intervene and share her perceptions while a leader is working with another client, but she may be inhibited because she is not sure whether she should interrupt the group leader at work. Another member may feel an inclination to support a fellow group member at the time when that member is experiencing some pain or sadness but may refrain because he is uncertain whether his support will detract from the other's experience. A member who rarely participates may keep her feelings, thoughts, and reactions to herself because she is not sure of the appropriateness of revealing them. Perhaps if she were told that it is useful to express her reactions, she might

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be more open with her group and, consequently, be able to participate in personal ways more frequently.

If group norms are clearly presented and members see the value of them and cooperatively decide to work with them, norms can be potent forces in shaping the group. Ideally, group norms will be developed in a collaborative way as much as possible rather than being handed down by the leader. Part of the orientation process consists of identifying and discussing norms that are aimed at developing a cohesive and productive group.

If members are struggling to abide by group norms, it may be useful to discuss this as a group and to evaluate how those norms were established and modeled. Members' unwillingness to adhere to group norms may be due to a lack of collaboration or an absence of role modeling and teaching by group leaders. It is important to establish norms that are developmentally appropriate for the group members in terms of age, emotional and social intelligence, and the readiness of members to change.

In the university graduate program in which I (Cindy) taught, we had a policy and an explicit norm pertaining to consensus decision making. The student group makes decisions collaboratively with leaders (faculty). We collapse the hierarchy as much as possible so the "community" can find ways to reach decisions that serve the whole community. This collaborative model results in enhanced group cohesion, but the process often poses challenges for students who come from backgrounds that are more hierarchical or individualistic. Students often struggle to adapt to a method that is not based on a simple "majority rules" concept. The complexity within this process often leads to the greatest learning on the part of group members, and in our experience it leads students to become more powerful change agents and community leaders. For many students, having a voice in what they learn and how they learn it increases ownership of their education and empowers them in ways they had not experienced in more traditionally organized educational settings.

Group Cohesion

During the early stage of a group, members do not know one another well enough for a true sense of community to be formed. There is usually some awkwardness as members become acquainted. Though participants talk about themselves, it is likely that they are presenting more of their public selves rather than deeper aspects of their private selves. **Group cohesion** is a sense of togetherness, or community, within a group, and it begins to take shape during the initial stage. Genuine cohesion typically comes after groups have struggled with conflict, have shared pain, and have committed themselves to taking significant risks. Members have incentives for remaining in the group and share a feeling of belongingness and relatedness. Members have committed to actively participating and to establishing a safe and accepting climate. Cohesion is a vital aspect of a group from the initial to final stages. We introduce cohesion here as a norm for the initial stage, and we return to this topic in more depth when we address the therapeutic factors operating during the working stage in Chapter 8.

Some indicators of this initial degree of cohesion are cooperation among members; a willingness to show up for the meetings and be punctual; an effort to make

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the group a safe place, including talking about any feelings of lack of trust or fears of trusting; support and caring, as evidenced by being willing to listen to others and accept them for who they are; and a willingness to express reactions to and perceptions of others in the here-and-now context of group interactions. Genuine cohesion is an ongoing process of solidarity that members earn through the risks they take with one another throughout the life of the group. Group cohesion can be developed, maintained, and increased in a number of ways. Here are some suggestions for enhancing group cohesion.

- Leaders can model meaningful sharing by sharing their own reactions to what is occurring within the group and encouraging members to take similar risks. When group members do take risks, they can be reinforced with sincere recognition and support, which will increase their sense of closeness to the others.
- Members can be encouraged to disclose their ideas, feelings, and reactions to what occurs within their group. The expression of both positive and negative reactions should be encouraged. If this is done, an honest exchange can take place, which is essential if a sense of group belongingness is to develop.
- Group goals and individual goals can be jointly determined by the group members and the leader. If a group is without clearly stated goals, animosity can build up that will lead to fragmentation of the group.
- Cohesion can be increased by inviting all members to become active participants. Members who are silent or withdrawn can be encouraged to express their reactions toward the group. These members may be observing and not verbally contributing for a number of reasons, and these reasons can be productively examined in the group.
- Group leaders can promote member-to-member interactions by asking the members to respond to one another, by encouraging feedback and sharing, and by searching for ways to involve as many members as possible in group interactions.
- Group leaders can increase the value of a group to its members by dealing with matters that interest group members, by showing respect for members, and by providing a supportive atmosphere.

Conflict frequently emerges in groups. It is desirable for group members to recognize sources of conflict and to deal openly with them when they arise. A group can be strengthened by acceptance of conflict and by the honest working through of interpersonal tensions. Members can be asked to predict how they are likely to handle conflict in the group when it arises and talk about their typical ways of dealing with conflict. Leaders can ask if members are willing to commit to working on more effective ways of dealing with conflict within the group. In a group we (Marianne and Jerry) led, we asked members about their style of managing conflict. One member said that if she got angry she would get up and leave the group. Another member said he would get quiet and stop talking. By giving voice to their typical patterns of behavior in conflict situations, we were able to contract with them to work on doing something different the next time conflict arose in the group. When group participants communicate their feelings out loud, leaders have an opportunity to intervene and work with members to come up with new ways of managing conflict that will enable them to move through a situation rather than staying stuck in it.

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Critical Incident

Should He Stay or Should He Go?

1. Description of Incident

During the first session of a personal-growth group, a heated interchange broke out between two members: Mr. Soto, an HIV-positive, Latino, gay man, and Mr. Ortiz, a Latino minister in a small Latino community. When Mr. Soto shared information about his sexual identity and HIV status, Mr. Ortiz expressed homophobic remarks such as that Mr. Soto was a "sinner" and was "being punished by God." Mr. Ortiz was direct and open with his anger at "gays" and expressed further disdain because Mr. Soto was a Latino and should be more of a "real man." This outburst had a strong effect on everyone in the room. Mr. Soto was extremely angry and hurt and began yelling back at Mr. Ortiz. Everyone in the room seemed stunned by the interchange, including the group leaders.

During a scheduled break in the group, the coleaders talked privately about whether it was appropriate for Mr. Ortiz to remain in the group and whether his homophobic attitudes might harm other group members. Because Mr. Ortiz would be counseling people in his congregation, the coleaders felt the minister needed the help that group participation might offer. The coleaders decided to meet with Mr. Ortiz at a later date and continued to process the conflict that occurred when they returned to the group.

2. Process Questions for Group Leaders

1. What feelings would Mr. Ortiz's comments evoke in you?
2. How would your reactions to Mr. Ortiz affect how you would work with him?
3. If you had a negative reaction to Mr. Ortiz, how would you address this, if at all?
4. If your personal values were similar to those of Mr. Ortiz, would you voice that? Why or why not?
5. If you held the same beliefs as Mr. Ortiz, how would this affect how you saw his actions and how you might intervene?
6. How would you intervene with Mr. Soto or other members of the group?
7. What concerns might you have about keeping Mr. Ortiz in the group?
8. If you decided to ask Mr. Ortiz to leave the group, how would you facilitate the process of removing him?
9. What ethical concerns do you have regarding this incident?
10. Does any part of you feel protective of Mr. Ortiz? If so, in what ways?
11. Would you meet with Mr. Ortiz privately to address your concerns, or would you do this in the group? Explain your reasons.

3. Clinical Reflections

Group leaders have a duty to create an environment in which all members feel safe and free from direct discrimination, and the leaders were extremely concerned about Mr. Ortiz's remarks and how his actions may have affected other group members. A group is in many ways a microcosm of society, and the leaders recognized that many of the beliefs Mr. Ortiz held were prevalent outside of the group (and perhaps held by some group members). The leaders wanted to minimize further harm to Mr. Soto and others who may have been on the receiving end of heterosexism and discrimination, but they also wanted to provide a space where members could work through conflict.

As the leaders processed their feelings in supervision, they realized that their first instinct was to remove Mr. Ortiz from the group. As they spoke further, they wondered aloud what it would be like to help Mr. Ortiz explore his homophobia without being verbally abusive. For example, what function did this belief serve in his life? How was he taught to believe as he did, and how might his own identity as a Latino minister be threatened if he did not object so directly? They also wondered if Mr. Ortiz may have used this outburst as a way to protect himself in the group and to avoid making himself vulnerable. Could the leaders use this situation to enhance assertive communication skills among group members and to model appropriate conflict resolution while enhancing safety within the group? The leaders wanted

continued

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to balance the opposing needs in the group, giving space to those who felt hurt or angry by what Mr. Ortiz said without shutting down the minister or shaming him into silence. How powerful might it be for the leaders to discuss this in the group session, modeling all of the issues and concerns with which they were wrestling?

4. Possible Interventions

1. Check in with Mr. Soto to see how he is feeling after hearing Mr. Ortiz's remarks. Create an opportunity for Mr. Soto to talk about the way homophobia has affected him in the past and present.
2. Invite other group members to share their reactions to the interchange.
3. Explore with Mr. Ortiz his own experience with discrimination.
4. Ask Mr. Ortiz to talk about how he learned what it meant to be a man.
5. Ask Mr. Ortiz what it would mean to his own identity as a Latino man and minister if he did not openly object to Mr. Soto. (Would he feel that his own sexual identity was threatened? Would he see himself as less masculine? Would his congregation judge him?)
6. Share your concerns with Mr. Ortiz about the harm his comments and attitudes can cause in the group and your ambivalent feelings about the pros and cons of his participation.

LO6

Effective Therapeutic Relationships: Research Findings

Research has yielded considerable evidence of the importance of a positive therapist–client relationship as a contributing factor to positive change in clients (Burlingame & Fuhriman, 1990). Three key constructs capture the essence of the therapeutic relationship in group treatment: group climate, cohesion, and alliances (Burlingame, Fuhriman, & Johnson 2002). Group leaders play a key role in creating a therapeutic group climate that encourages member-to-member feedback and participation as key group norms.

Support Versus Confrontation

Forging an effective group requires achieving an appropriate balance between support and confrontation. Groups that stress confrontation as a requisite for peeling away the defensive behaviors of members lead to increasingly defensive interactions. The reviews of research that describe negative outcomes in groups consistently cite aggressive confrontation as the leadership style with the highest risks (Yalom, 2005b). As group leaders become overly confrontational and actively negative, the odds are that members will be dissatisfied and potentially harmed by the group experience. Leaders should avoid confrontational interventions until they have earned that right by building a trusting relationship with the members. Once the foundation of interpersonal trust is established, group members tend to be more open to challenge (Dies, 1994).

When confrontations are rooted in compassion, members will often be receptive to such interventions.

How leaders challenge members does much to set the tone of the group. Members have a tendency to follow the leader's manner of confronting. When

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confrontations are rooted in compassion, members will often be receptive to such interventions. In addition, leaders should be clear about what role confrontation occupies in their theoretical orientation. There is no single right way to confront members. What works for some may not work for others. We need to be secure in our role as leaders and trust that confrontations are a part of counseling as well as be willing to adapt when our style of challenging others seems ineffective.

Guidelines for Creating Therapeutic Relationships With Members

In this section we present further guidelines for group leadership practice based on research summaries done by Burlingame, Fuhriman, and Johnson (2002, 2004b) and Morran, Stockton, and Whittingham (2004).

- Strive for positive involvement in the group through genuine, empathic, and caring interactions with members. Impersonal, detached, and judgmental leadership styles can thwart the development of trust and cohesion.
- Develop a reasonably open therapeutic style characterized by appropriate and facilitative self-disclosure. Be willing to share your own reactions and emotional experiences, especially as they relate to events and relationships within the group.
- Keep in mind that leader self-disclosure can have either a constructive or a detrimental effect on the group process and outcome, depending on specific factors such as the type of group, the stage of its development, and the content and manner of the disclosure.
- Help members make maximum use of effective role models, especially those members who demonstrate desirable behavior. Members can be encouraged to learn from one another. If you have a coleader, model openness with your partner.
- Provide an adequate amount of structuring, especially during the early phase of a group, but avoid a controlling style of leadership.
- Provide opportunities for all members to make maximum use of the group's resources by teaching members skills of active participation in the group process.
- Demonstrate your caring by being willing to confront members when that is called for, but do so in a manner that provides members with good modeling of ways to confront sensitively.
- Set and reinforce clear norms as one way to establish cohesion within the group.
- When necessary, protect group members and strive to promote a feeling of safety.
- Intervene when a member is preventing others from using the group's resources by engaging in nonconstructive confrontations, sarcasm, and indirect exchanges. Help members deal with one another in direct, respectful, and constructive ways.

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We want to underscore our belief that you can do much to encourage members to give up some of their defensiveness by reacting to them in respectful ways. Members are more likely to develop a stance of openness in a group that they perceive as being safe for them, and your modeling has a lot to do with creating this therapeutic atmosphere.

Group leaders often have to balance care, confrontation, modeling, and cultural competence simultaneously. For example, a group member (Kim) frequently expressed a sense of being trapped and suffocated by strict gender roles within her culture. She described her situation as hopeless and said there was nothing she could do to change her life. As a group leader, I (Cindy) felt stuck with how to challenge her yet remain culturally sensitive to her personal dilemma. In challenging Kim, I needed to be as transparent as possible, letting her know that I cared very much for her, and that I recognized the possible ramifications of any changes she might make in her cultural environment. Working with Kim took time and patience, yet I was able to challenge her because she felt that I cared both about her and about her culture. Other group members who had diverse cultural backgrounds observed my work with Kim and had a chance to decide for themselves whether they could trust me. It is important to be authentic and to allow trust to unfold rather than attempt to "prove" ourselves trustworthy. By doing this, we further model our belief and trust in the group process.

LO7

Helping Members Get the Most From a Group Experience

Some behaviors and attitudes promote a cohesive and productive group—that is, a group in which meaningful self-exploration takes place and in which honest and appropriate feedback is given and received. We begin orienting and preparing members during the preliminary session, but we typically find that time allows only an introduction to the ways in which clients can get the most from their group experience. Consequently, during the initial phase of the group's evolution, we devote some time to teaching members the basics of group process, especially how they can involve themselves as active participants. We emphasize that they will benefit from the experience in direct proportion to how much they invest of themselves, both in the group and in practicing on the outside what they are learning in the sessions.

We do not present group guidelines as a lecture in one sitting, and we do not overwhelm members with more information than can be assimilated at one time. We begin by giving members written information about their participation in the group. We also allocate time to discuss these topics as they occur naturally within the sessions, which increases the likelihood that members will be receptive to thinking about how they can best participate. We continue to provide information in a timely manner at various points in a group. We encourage you to use these guidelines as a catalyst for thinking about your own approach to preparing members. Reflecting on this material may help you develop an approach that suits your own personality and leadership style and that is appropriate for the groups you lead. The following suggestions are written from the leader's point of view and directed to the members.

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Leader Guidelines for Members

Building Trust We are convinced that confidentiality is essential if members are to feel a sense of safety in a group. Even if nobody raises questions about the nature and limitations of confidentiality, we still emphasize the importance of respecting the confidential character of the interactions within the group and caution members about how it can be broken. We explain how easy it might be to breach confidentiality without intending to do so. We emphasize to members that it is their responsibility to continually make the room safe by addressing their concerns regarding how their disclosures will be treated. If members feel that others may talk outside the sessions, this uncertainty is bound to hamper their ability to fully participate.

In our groups the members frequently hear from us that it does not make sense to open up quickly without a foundation of safety. One way to create this safe and trusting environment is for the group members to be willing to verbalize their fears, concerns, and here-and-now reactions during the early sessions. It is up to each member to decide what to bring into group and how far to pursue these personal topics. Participants often wait for some other person to take the first risk or to make some gesture of trust. They can challenge this, paradoxically, by revealing their fear of trust. Members can gain from initiating a discussion that will allow genuine trust to develop.

> **EXAMPLE:** Harold was older than most of the other group members, and he was afraid that they would not be able to empathize with him, that they would exclude him from activities, and that they would view him as an outsider—a parent figure. After he disclosed these fears, many members let Harold know how much they appreciated his willingness to reveal his fears. His disclosure, and the response to it, stimulated others to express some of their concerns. This sharing stimulated trust in the entire group by making it clear that it was appropriate to express fears. Instead of being rejected, Harold felt accepted and appreciated because he had been willing to make a significant part of himself known to the rest of the group.

Expressing Persistent Feelings Sometimes members keep their feelings of disinterest, anger, or disappointment a secret from the rest of the group. It is most important that persistent feelings related to the group process be aired. We often make statements to members such as "If you are feeling detached and withdrawn, let it be known" or "If you are experiencing chronic anger or irritation toward others in this group, don't keep these feelings to yourself."

> **EXAMPLE:** In a group of adolescents that met once a week for 10 weeks, Luella waited until the third session to disclose that she did not trust either the members or the leader, that she was angry because she felt pressured to participate, and that she really did not know what was expected of her as a group member. She had experienced reluctance since the initial session but had not verbalized her reactions. The leader let Luella know how important it was for her to reveal these persistent feelings of distrust so they could be explored and resolved.

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Self-Disclosure Group members are sometimes led to believe that the more they disclose about themselves, the better. Though self-disclosure is an important tool in the group process, it is up to each participant to decide what aspects of his or her life to reveal. This principle cannot be stressed too much, for the idea that members will have to "tell everything" contributes to the reservations of many people to becoming participants in a group.

The most useful kind of disclosure expresses a present concern and may entail some vulnerability and risk. As participants open up to a group, they have fears about how other people will receive what they reveal. If a member shares that he is shy, often quiet, and afraid to speak up in the group, the other members will have a frame of reference for more accurately interpreting and reacting to his lack of participation. Had he not spoken up, both the leader and other members would have been more likely to misinterpret his behavior.

Self-disclosure is not a process of making oneself psychologically naked. Members need to understand that they are responsible for deciding *what*, *how much*, and *when* they will share personal conflicts pertaining to their everyday life.

EXAMPLE: In a weekly group, Luis earlier disclosed that he was gay. At work he had not been willing to talk openly about his sexual orientation. Although Luis was willing to share with his group many of his struggles in being a gay Latino, he said he was not ready to talk about the difficulties he was experiencing in his relationship. At this time in his life, Luis felt shame about his sexual orientation, especially with respect to his extended family. Although it was difficult for him to talk about his feelings about being gay in the group, Luis challenged himself to trust others with some of his deepest concerns. One of the cultural values he grew up with was to keep personal concerns private. Although he did not feel comfortable discussing his relationship with his partner, Luis was willing to share with the group many of his doubts, fears, and anxieties over not being accepted for who he was. Luis did not want to go through life living a lie. Other group members respected Luis for his willingness to explore his struggles about being gay, especially his fear of judgment and rejection. Because of this understanding that he felt from other members, Luis was able to share more of his life in the group than he could do with anyone outside of the group.

Participating Fully A participant might say, "I'm not the talkative type. It's hard for me to formulate my thoughts, and I'm afraid I don't express myself well. So I usually don't say anything in the group. But I listen to what others are saying, and I learn by observing. I really don't think I have to be talking all the time to get something out of these sessions." Although it is true that members can learn by observing interactions and reacting nonverbally, their learning tends to be limited. If members assume the stance of not contributing, others will never come to know them, and they can easily feel cheated and angry at being the object of others' perhaps flawed observations.

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Some members keep themselves on the fringe of group activity by continually saying, "I have no real problems in my life at this time, so I don't have much to contribute to the group." Other members remain passive by stating that they see no need to repeat what other members have already expressed because they feel the same way. We attempt to teach these members to share their reactions to their experience in the group as well as to let others know how they are being affected. Members who choose to share little about events outside of the group can actively participate by keeping themselves open to being affected by other members. Leaders can contribute to group cohesion by helping those members who feel that they have nothing to contribute recognize that they can at least share how they are reacting personally to what others are saying.

EXAMPLE: When Thelma was asked what she wanted from the group, she replied, "I haven't really given it that much thought. I figured I'd just be spontaneous and wait to see what happens." The leader let Thelma know that sometimes other people's work might indeed evoke some of her own issues and that she might spontaneously react. However, the leader pointed out to her that it was important for her to think about and to bring up the concerns that initially brought her to the group. As the sessions progressed, Thelma did learn to let the other members know what she wanted from them, and she began to take the initiative. She showed that she wanted to talk about how lonely she was, how desperate and inadequate she frequently felt, how fearful she was of being vulnerable with men, and how she dreaded facing her world every morning. As she moved from observer to active participant, Thelma found that she could benefit from her weekly sessions.

Embracing Change Participants in therapeutic groups should be given the warning that their involvement may complicate their outside lives for a time. As a result of group experiences, members tend to assume that the people in their lives will be both ready and willing to make significant changes. It can be shocking for members to discover that others thought they were "just fine" the way they were, and the friction that results may make it more difficult than ever to modify familiar patterns. Therefore, it is important for members to be prepared for the fact that not everyone will like or accept some of the changes they want to make.

EXAMPLE: Ricardo came away from his group with the awareness that he was frightened of his wife, that he consistently refrained from expressing his wants to her, and that he related to her as he would to a protective mother. If he asserted himself with her, he feared that she would leave. In the group he not only became tired of his dependent style but also decided that he would treat his wife as an equal and give up his hope of having her become his mother. Ricardo's wife did not cooperate with his valiant efforts to change the nature of their relationship. The more assertive he became, the more disharmony there was in his home. While he was trying to become independent, his wife was struggling to keep their relationship the way it was; she was not willing to respond differently to him.

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Discovering New Dimensions of Yourself Oftentimes people in groups begin to realize that they can control more aspects of their lives than they previously thought possible. When members explore intense feelings of pain in a group, they may come to realize that this unrecognized and unexpressed pain is blocking them from living a truly joyous life. By working through these painful experiences, they begin to reclaim a joyful dimension of themselves. For instance, many participants experience an inner strength, discover a real wit and sense of humor, create moving poetry or songs, or dare for the first time to show a creative side of themselves that they have kept hidden from others and from themselves.

> **EXAMPLE:** Finn expressed the positive side of group experience when he remarked, "I used to think that what I had to say didn't matter and that I had little to offer. Through my interactions with people here, I have come to realize that what I feel and say makes a difference to others and is even highly valued at times."

Listening Group members can be taught to listen carefully to what the other members say about them, neither accepting it entirely nor rejecting it outright. Members are advised to be as open as possible, yet to also listen discriminatingly, deciding for themselves what does and what does not apply to them. Before they respond, they can be asked to listen and to let what is being said to them sink in, and to take note of how it is affecting them. Members cannot fully comprehend what is being communicated to them if they are not totally engaged in listening.

> **EXAMPLE:** In an adolescent group, members told Brendan that it was hard for them to listen to his many stories. Although some of his stories were interesting, they gave no clue to the nature of his struggles, which were the reason he was in the group. Other members told him that it was easier to hear what he was saying when he talked about himself. Brendan became defensive and angry and denied that he had been acting that way. The leader asked Brendan to observe himself, both in the group and in everyday life, and to think about how he was affected by the feedback and to consider what had been said to him before he so rigorously rejected the feedback.

Taking in Feedback Members will learn that feedback is a valuable source of information that they can use in assessing what they are doing in the group and how their behavior is affecting others. Members do well to listen carefully to consistent feedback they receive. A person may get similar feedback from many people in different groups yet may still dismiss it as invalid. Although it is important to discriminate, it is also important to realize that a message that has been received from a variety of people is likely to have some degree of validity.

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EXAMPLE: In several groups Liam heard people tell him that he did not seem interested in what they had to say and that he appeared distant and detached. Although Liam was physically in the room, he often looked at the ceiling and sighed, moved his chair away from the circle, and yawned a lot. Members wondered out loud if he was interested in them and said that it was difficult for them to get close to him. Liam was surprised by this feedback and insisted that his behavior in the group was very different from his behavior in his outside life—that on the outside he felt close to people and was interested and involved. It seems unlikely that someone could be so different in the two areas, however, and the leader intervened in this way: "You may be different in here than you are on the outside. But would you be willing to notice how people respond to you away from here and be open to noticing if any of the feedback given to you might be similar?" The leader's response eliminated unnecessary argumentation and debates over who was right.

Other Suggestions for Group Members Some additional guidelines for group members that we bring up early in a group, as they seem appropriate, are briefly listed here:

- Be willing to do work both before and after a group. Consider keeping a journal as a supplement to the group experience. Create homework assignments as a way of putting your group learning into practice in everyday living.
- Develop self-evaluation skills as a way of assessing your progress in the group. Ask yourself these questions: "Am I contributing to the group?" "Am I satisfied with what is occurring in the sessions? If not, what am I doing about it?" "Am I using in my life what I'm learning in my group?"
- Spend time clarifying your own goals by reviewing specific issues and themes you want to explore during the sessions. This can best be done by thinking about specific changes you want to make in your life and by deciding what you are willing to do both in and out of the group to bring about these changes.
- Concentrate on making personal and direct statements to others in your group, as opposed to giving advice, making interpretations, and asking impersonal questions. Instead of telling others how they are, let them know how they are affecting you.
- Realize that the real work consists of what you actually do outside of your group. Consider the group as a means to an end, and give some time to thinking about what you will do with what you are learning. Expect some setbacks, and be aware that change may be slow and subtle.

Avoid Too Much Structuring and Teaching

Even though we have stressed the value of preparing members for how groups function, be aware that too much emphasis on providing information about the group process can have a negative influence. All the spontaneous learning can

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be taken out of the group experience if members have been told too much of what to expect and have not been allowed to learn for themselves. Moreover, it is possible to foster a dependency on the structure and direction provided by the leader.

We hope that members will increasingly be able to function with less intervention from the leader as the group progresses. There is a delicate balance between providing too much structure and failing to give enough structure and information. Especially important, perhaps, is that the leader be aware of factors such as group cohesion, group norms, and group interactions at any given point. With this awareness the leader can decide when it is timely and useful to suggest a discussion of certain behavior that is occurring in the here and now.

As we stated earlier, the stages in the life of a group are not rigidly defined but are fluid and somewhat overlapping. How we teach members about the group process can have a lot to do with the level to which the group may evolve. Yalom (2005b) has identified particular therapeutic characteristics that are primarily linked to the various stages of a group. During the beginning phase, the crucial factors are identification, universality, hope, and cohesion. During the middle phase, catharsis, cohesion, interpersonal learning, and insight are essential. As termination approaches, existential factors surface. Understanding these group characteristics will aid you in deciding how much to teach—and when.

Journal Writing as an Adjunct to Group Sessions

Group members can add to the group experience by participating in journal writing exercises outside of the group. One way is to ask members to spend even a few minutes each day recording in a journal certain feelings, situations, behaviors, and ideas for courses of action. Alternatively, members can be asked to review certain periods of time in their lives and write about them. For example, they can get out pictures of their childhood years and other reminders of this period and then freely write in a journal whatever comes to mind. Writing in a free-flowing style without censoring can be of great help in getting a focus on feelings.

Members can bring the journals to the group and share a particular experience they had that resulted in problems for them. They can then explore with the group how they might have handled the situation differently. In general, however, these journals help members improve their personal focus for a session, and as such, members can decide what to do with the material they write.

Another way to use journals is as a preparation for encountering others in everyday life. For instance, Jenny is having a great deal of difficulty talking with her husband. She is angry with him much of the time over many of the things he does and does not do. But she sits on this anger, and she feels sad that they do not take time for each other. Jenny typically does not express her sadness to him, nor does she let him know of her resentment toward him for not being involved in their children's lives. To deal with this problem, she can write her husband a detailed and uncensored letter pointing out all the ways she feels angry, hurt, sad,

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and disappointed and expressing how she would like their life to be different. It is not recommended that she show this letter to her husband. The letter writing is a way for her to clarify what she feels and to prepare herself to work in the group. This work can then help her to be clear about what she wants to say to her husband as well as how she wants to say it. This process works in the following way: In the group Jenny can talk to another member by relating the essence of what she wrote in her letter. This member can role play Jenny's husband. Others can then express how they experience Jenny and the impact on the way she spoke. Aided by such feedback, she may be able to find a constructive way to express her feelings to her husband.

Still another technique is for members to spontaneously enter in their journals their reactions to themselves in the group, especially during the first few meetings, and to review these thoughts as the group is coming to an end. Answering these questions can help members understand their group experience:

- How do I see myself in this group?
- How do I feel about being in the group?
- What reactions do I notice myself having to people in this group?
- What are my initial fears or concerns about being in the group?
- How do I most want to use the time in the group sessions?
- What would I like to leave this group having learned or experienced?

If participants write down their reactions, they are more likely to verbalize them during group sessions. If members are afraid to open up in a group because they think others may judge them in a negative way, writing about this in a journal can prepare members for expressing these fears verbally during group sessions.

In our groups we strongly encourage members to engage in regular journal writing as a part of their homework. Depending on the needs of a group, we might suggest some incomplete sentences for members to spontaneously complete either at the end of a group meeting or as material for journaling at home.

Here are some incomplete sentence assignments that work well in the initial stage of a group:

- What I most want from this group is . . .
- The one thing I most want to be able to say about the changes I am making at our final meeting is . . .
- When I think about being in this group for the next 12 weeks, I . . .
- A fear I have about being a group member is . . .
- One personal concern or problem I would hope to bring up is . . .
- My most dominant reaction to being in the group so far is . . .
- The one aspect I'd most like to change about myself is . . .

The incomplete sentence technique helps members focus on specific aspects of their experience during the early sessions, and several of these questions pertain to member goals. The practice of reflecting on personal goals, and writing about them, is an excellent means of clarifying what it is members want and how they can best obtain what they want.

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Journal Prompts

The following questions are meant to serve as prompts for members of a group during the initial stages. If you are leading groups, you might find it useful for group members to either discuss these questions in group or journal about them between sessions. In addition, we encourage you to think about your responses to these questions as either a real or imagined group member.

1. In what ways did you test the group, the leaders, or individuals?
2. How willing were you to take risks in the group?
3. How close or distant did you feel to the group, the leaders, or to individuals?
4. In what ways did you feel included or excluded, and how did you or others contribute to this dynamic?
5. What contributed to your ability or inability to trust group members or leaders?
6. What negative or positive reactions did you have to group members, leaders, or individuals?

Homework During the Initial Stage

Perhaps one of the best ways to maximize the value of any group experience is to design homework assignments that members can carry out both in and out of the group. Group leaders can model active participation and collaboration by their involvement with members in creating an agenda, designing homework, and teaching skills and new behaviors.

Homework can be a valuable instrument to ensure behavioral change. The more time group members are willing to commit to working on their problems outside of the therapeutic context, the more likely it is that they will make positive gains (Ledley, Marx, & Heimberg, 2010). In Chapter 4 we discussed homework as a cognitive behavioral strategy, but homework can be incorporated into any group, regardless of the leader's theoretical foundation. Homework assignments provide a valuable opportunity to reinforce and extend the benefits of the work done during therapy sessions. It is important for leaders to review homework and the outcomes of the assignment. Members can be asked what difficulties they encountered in trying to complete their homework.

LO8

Leader Issues at the Initial Stage

Early in the history of a group it is especially important to think about the balance of responsibility between members and the leader (or coleaders) as well as the degree of structuring that is optimal for the group. If you are working with a coleader, discussing these issues is essential because divergent views are bound to hurt the group. If you assume the majority of the responsibility for keeping the group moving, for example, and your coleader assumes almost no responsibility on the ground that the members must decide for themselves what to do with

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group time, the members will sense this division and are bound to be confused by it. Similarly, if you function best with a high degree of structure in groups and your coleader believes any structuring should come from the members, this difference of opinion will have a detrimental effect on the group. It is wise to select a coleader who has a philosophy of leadership that is compatible with yours, although this does not mean that both of you need to have the same *style* of leading. Effective coleaders often have differences that complement each other.

When differences between leaders result in conflict between them, it can be a source of anxiety for both members and leaders. If handled skillfully, leaders can model healthy confrontation and conflict resolution for group members. Modeling nondefensiveness and a willingness to challenge and be challenged by one another can prove to be a valuable learning opportunity. It is likely that some group members come from families in which the "parental" or "authority" figures fought in destructive or abusive ways. It can be a healing experience for group members to see the group leaders manage a conflict well. On the other hand, a badly handled conflict or confrontation places an unfair burden on the members and in extreme cases can be harmful to the group process and outcome. It is up to the leaders to determine whether the issue is best addressed in the moment with the group members or in private between the leaders. There are pros and cons to both of these approaches. If the members witnessed the conflict, we prefer to address it in the group.

Division of Responsibility

A basic issue you will have to consider is responsibility for the direction and outcome of the group. If a group proves to be nonproductive, will this failure stem from your lack of leadership skills, or does the responsibility rest with the group members?

We tend to be highly active during the initial period in the evolution of a group. In our view, it is our responsibility to intervene in very directive ways to establish certain norms within the group. Our intention is not to promote leader dependency but to teach members how they can best attain what they want to accomplish by being a part of this group. We encourage members to take an active role in the process of monitoring what they are thinking, feeling, and doing and to pay attention to the times when they may be engaging in behavior that is not going to help them in this group.

We strive to balance responsibility between leaders and members. We encourage group leaders to make use of journal writing to clarify how much responsibility they are assuming for the overall functioning of the group. When training group leaders, we ask them to write about themselves and the reactions that are evoked in them as they lead or colead their groups. Rather than describing the dynamics of their members, we suggest that they focus on how specific members affect them personally. Here are some questions we recommend that group leaders address and write about in their journals:

- How did I feel about myself as I was leading or coleading my group?
- How much responsibility did I assume for the outcome of this particular session?

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- What did I like best about the group today?
- What most stood out for me during this session?
- How am I being affected personally by each of the members?
- How involved am I in this group? If I am not as involved as I would like to be, what specific steps am I willing to take to change this situation?
- Are any factors getting in the way of me effectively leading this group?

This journal technique for group leaders provides an excellent record of patterns that are shaping up in a group. The practice of writing can also be a useful catalyst for focusing leaders on areas in their own lives that need continued attention. These questions can be useful when discussing your group experience with your coleader or supervisors. Spending time thinking about and expressing your experiences can help tremendously in refining your effectiveness and development as a leader.

Degree of Structuring

The issue is not *whether* a group leader should provide structure but *what degree* of structure should be provided. Like responsibility, structuring exists on a continuum. The leader's theoretical orientation, the type of group, the membership population, and the stage of the group are some of the factors that determine the amount and type of structuring employed. Person-centered groups have a limited degree of leader structuring because counselors have faith in the members of the group and in the group process itself. Leader-imposed structuring is likely to undermine this trust in the group to move in a constructive direction. In contrast, most cognitive behavior group counselors rely on a clear structure for each session. The group leader would have a clear plan for each session even though the leader would seek participation of the group members in deciding how to use the session.

Research indicates the positive value of an initial structure that builds supportive group norms and highlights positive interactions among members. Leaders must carefully monitor this therapeutic structure throughout the life of a group. Structuring that offers a coherent framework for understanding the experiences of individuals and the group process is of the most value. Yalom (1983, 2005b) sees the basic task of the group leader as providing enough structure to give a general direction to the members while avoiding the pitfalls of fostering dependency. Yalom's (2005b) message for leaders is to structure the group in a fashion that facilitates each member's autonomous functioning. An example of fostering dependency on the leader would be encouraging members to speak only when they are invited to do so. Instead, the leader can encourage members to bring themselves into the interactions without being called on.

Our style of structuring is aimed at reducing unnecessary floundering and maximizing full participation. We do this by teaching participants a number of ways to derive the maximum benefit from a group. By providing some structure, we give group members the opportunity to experiment with new levels of awareness and to build new forms of behavior from this awareness. During the initial stage, our structure is aimed at helping members identify and express their fears,

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expectations, and personal goals. We often use dyads, go-arounds, and open-ended questions to make it easier for members to talk to one another about current issues in their lives. After talking to several people on a one-to-one basis, members find it easier to talk openly in the entire group. The leadership activity we provide is designed to help members focus on themselves and the issues they most want to explore in the group.

Many short-term psychoeducational groups are structured around a series of topics. In a group for learning effective parenting skills, for example, the sessions are guided by topics such as listening well, setting limits, learning to convey respect, and providing discipline without punishment. Group leaders sometimes strictly adhere to a structured exercise or a discussion of a topic when another pressing matter demands attention. If there is conflict in the group, it is more important to suspend the topic or exercise until the conflict has been attended to. If the conflict is brushed aside, there is a greater likelihood that discussion of the topic will be superficial. At other times members may spontaneously bring up unrelated concerns, and leaders have difficulty keeping the group focused on the topic in a meaningful way. The leader and members of the group need to explore whether the shift in the topic is due to their discomfort with the issue or to the fact that a more relevant subject has surfaced. If the shift is an avoidance tactic, the facilitator might point out the dynamics of what is occurring. The art consists in learning how to help members relate topics to themselves in significant ways so that group interaction and group learning can occur. The effective leader provides just enough guidance so that group members can take responsibility for defining their own structure.

Opening and Closing Group Sessions

LO9

We discuss opening and closing group sessions here because it is an essential aspect of group leadership from the very beginning. These skills are important throughout the group process, and we suggest that you return to this discussion as you read about subsequent stages. The interventions we describe here are not the only "right" ones. There are many effective ways to intervene, depending on your theoretical orientation or leadership style and also on the kind of group you are leading. We have found the following guidelines useful.

Guidelines for Opening Each Group Session Sometimes group leaders focus on the person who speaks first and may stay with that member for an undue length of time. Other common oversights include neglecting to link a present session with the previous session or failing to check in to determine how members want to use the time for a particular session. Starting a session with a brief check-in can set the group up to involve as many members as possible in productive work for that session. In our training workshops, we (Marianne and Jerry) are sometimes asked if we participate in this check-in process. If we have something on our minds pertaining to the group, we are likely to remark on this during the check-in. However, more often than not we do not participate, especially if we are asking members to state what they want to talk about or explore in this session.

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For groups that meet on a regular basis, such as once a week, we suggest some of the following procedures to open each session in an effective way:

- Ask all members to participate in a check-in process by briefly stating what they want from the session. During the check-in time, our aim is to hear what the members remember from the last session and what they want to say. A quick go-around is all that is needed for members to identify issues they are interested in pursuing; in this way an agenda can be developed that is based on some common concerns. We generally do not stay with one member before we have completed the check-in process because we want all the participants to have a chance to express what they are bringing to this session. If you stay with the first member who speaks, a norm is developed that the first person to speak will be the focus of work for much of a session. The check-in procedure provides a basis for identifying emerging themes present at the beginning of a meeting. If you do not find out what issues the members have brought to a particular session, much important material will be lost.
- Give members a brief opportunity to share what they have done in the way of practice outside of the group since the previous session. If members are making use of journal writing and carrying out homework assignments, the beginning of a session is a good time for members to briefly state some of the outcomes of their reflections, writing, and homework. Some may want to talk about problems they are experiencing in transferring their learning from the group into everyday situations. This difficulty can then be the basis for work in that session.
- Ask members if they have any thoughts or unresolved feelings about the previous session. If members do not have a chance to mention these concerns, hidden agendas will probably develop and block effective work. However, we avoid working on it during the check-in. It is important to get a commitment from members to address their concerns once the check-in has been completed.
- Have members form dyads to discuss how they would like to use the time in this session. After about 5 minutes, each person can state what was shared in the dyad. This exercise helps members take an active part in the session and is a good way to formulate an agenda.
- We begin some sessions by asking members to briefly state what they have been thinking regarding how the group is progressing. This practice is especially appropriate when we see certain problems emerging or when we sense the group is getting stuck. Our self-disclosure can lead the way for members to be open with their reactions to what is or is not going on in the sessions, especially if we state our reactions in a nonblaming way.
- In an open group (in which the membership changes somewhat from week to week), it is a good practice to introduce any new members. Rather than putting the spotlight on the incoming member, we favor asking the continuing members to briefly reflect on what they have been learning about themselves in the group. We recognize that some members may be attending for only a few sessions, thus we tend to ask them how they expect to get the most from their brief time in the group. We sometimes ask this question: "If this were the only session you had, what would you most want to accomplish?"

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- Introduce a session with a mindfulness exercise to bring members into the present moment. **Mindfulness** can be thought of as "awareness of present experience with acceptance" (R. Siegel, 2010, p. 27). In mindfulness practice, group members train themselves to intentionally focus on their present experience in a nonjudgmental way. The mindfulness skills learned in the group can be practiced in all of their daily activities, including being mindful when standing, walking, eating, and doing chores. For a good introduction to mindfulness practice, we recommend Ron Siegel's (2010) book, *The Mindfulness Solution: Everyday Practices for Everyday Problems.*

Although we do not suggest that you memorize certain lines to open a session, the following questions may be useful prompts for you in opening a session.

- What were you thinking and feeling before coming to the group?
- Before we begin today's session, I'd like to ask each of you to take a few minutes to silently review your week and think about anything you want to tell us.
- Who in the group were you most aware of as you were coming here today?
- Did anyone have any afterthoughts about last week's session?
- Who are you most aware of in this room right now, and why?
- What would you most like to be able to say by the end of this session?
- What is one thing you can do differently in this group to help you reach your goals?
- To what degree are you applying what you are learning in this group to your daily life?

Guidelines for Closing Each Group Session Just as important as how you open a session is the way in which you bring each meeting to a close. Too often a leader will simply announce that "time is up for today," with no attempt to summarize and integrate and with no encouragement for members to practice certain skills. Our preference for closing each group meeting is to establish a norm of expecting each member to participate in a brief checkout process. Some time, if even only 10 minutes, should be set aside to give participants an opportunity to reflect on what they liked or did not like about the session, to mention what they hope to do outside of the group during the week, and to give some indication of how they experienced the session. Attention to closing ensures that consolidation of learning will take place.

For groups that meet weekly, summarize what occurred in that session. At times, it is useful to stop the group halfway through the session and say, "I notice that we have about an hour left today, and I'd like to ask how each of you feels about what you've done so far today. Have you been as involved as you want to be? Are there some things you'd like to raise before this session ends?" This does not need to be done routinely, but sometimes such an assessment during the session can help members focus their attention on problem areas, especially if we notice that they are not talking about what they stated they needed to address.

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In closing a weekly group meeting, consider these guidelines:

- Not everyone will feel comfortable or think that every concern raised has been dealt with adequately. Group members can reflect on what they experienced during a session and can bring their concerns back to the following session.
- If participants report feeling uninvolved, we tend to ask them what they are willing to do to increase their investment in the group: "Is your lack of involvement all right, or is this something that you want to change?"
- Members can be asked to tell the group briefly what they are learning about themselves through their relationships with other members. The participants can briefly indicate some ways they have changed their behavior in response to these insights. If participants find that they would like to change their behavior even more, they can be encouraged to develop specific plans or homework assignments to complete before the next session.
- If members suggest homework that seems unrealistic, the leader can help members refine their ideas into more manageable homework assignments.
- Members can be asked if there are any topics, questions, or problems they would like to put on the agenda for the next session. This request creates a link between one session and the next.
- Members can give one another feedback. Especially helpful are members' positive reactions concerning what they have actually observed. For instance, if Doug's voice is a lot more secure, others may let him know that they perceive this change.
- If your group is one with changing membership, remind members a week before certain participants will be leaving the group. Not only do the terminating members need to talk about what they have learned from the group, but other members may want to share their reactions as well.
- Identify any unfinished business, even if it cannot be explored before the group session ends.

As we did for opening sessions, we offer some comments to consider in ending a particular session. Of course, not all of them need be asked at any one time:

- What was it like for you to be in this group today?
- What affected you the most, and what did you learn?
- What would each of you be willing to do outside of the group this week to practice some of the new skills you are acquiring?
- I'd like a quick go-around to have everyone say a few words on how this group has been so far.
- What are you getting or not getting from this group?
- If you are not satisfied with what is happening in this group, what can you do to change things?
- Before we close, I'd like to share with you some of my reactions and observations of this session.
- Before ending today, I'd like everyone to share the color that best represents you after experiencing group today. How did it change from the beginning of group?

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By developing skills in opening and closing sessions, you increase the possibility of continuity from meeting to meeting. Such continuity can help members transfer insights and new behaviors from the group into daily life and, along with encouragement and direction from your leadership, can facilitate the participants' ongoing assessment of their level of investment for each session.

If you work with a coleader, the matter of how the sessions are opened and closed should be a topic for discussion. Here are a few questions for exploration:

- Who typically opens the sessions?
- Do the two of you agree on when and how to bring a session to a close?
- With 5 minutes left in the sessions, does one leader want to continue working, whereas the other wants to attempt some summary of the meeting?
- Do both of you pay attention to unfinished business that might be left toward the end of a session?

Although we are not suggesting a mechanical division of time and functions when you begin and end sessions, it is worth noting who tends to assume this responsibility. If one leader typically opens the session, members may be likely to direct their talk to this person. In our groups one of us may open the session while the other elaborates and makes additional remarks. In this way spontaneous give-and-take between coleaders can replace an approach characterized by "Now it's your turn to make a remark."



Points to Remember

Initial Stages of a Group

Initial Stage Characteristics

The early phase of a group is a time for orientation and determining the structure of the group. At this stage:

- Participants test the atmosphere and get acquainted.
- Members learn what is expected, how the group functions, and how to participate in a group.
- Risk-taking is relatively low, and exploration is tentative.
- Group cohesion and trust are gradually established if members are willing to express what they are thinking and feeling as it pertains to being in the group.
- Members are concerned with whether they are included or excluded, and they are beginning to define their place in the group.
- Negative reactions may surface as members test to determine whether all feelings are acceptable.
- Trust versus mistrust is a central issue.
- Periods of silence and awkwardness may occur; members may look for direction and wonder what the group is about.
- Members are deciding whom they can trust, how much they will disclose, how safe the group is, whom they like and dislike, and how much to get involved.
- Members are learning the basic attitudes of respect, empathy, acceptance, caring, and responding—all attitudes that facilitate building trust.

Member Functions

Early in the course of the group some specific member roles and tasks are critical to shaping the group:

- Take active steps to create a trusting climate; distrust and fear will increase members' reluctance to participate.
- Learn to express your feelings and thoughts, especially as they pertain to interactions in the group.

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- Be willing to express fears, hopes, concerns, reservations, and expectations concerning the group.
- Be willing to make yourself known to the others in the group; members who remain hidden will not have meaningful interactions with the group.
- As much as possible, be involved in the creation of group norms.
- Establish personal and specific goals that will govern group participation.
- Learn the basics of group process, especially how to be involved in group interactions; problem solving and advice giving interrupt positive group interactions among members.

Leader Functions

The major tasks of group leaders during the orientation and exploration phase of a group are these:

- Teach participants some general guidelines and ways to participate actively that will increase their chances of having a productive group.
- Develop ground rules and set norms.
- Teach and reinforce the basics of group process.
- Assist members in expressing their fears and expectations, and work toward the development of trust.
- Model the facilitative dimensions of therapeutic behavior.
- Be open with the members and be psychologically present for them.
- Clarify the division of responsibility.
- Help members establish concrete personal goals.
- Deal openly with members' concerns and questions.
- Provide a degree of structuring that will neither increase members' dependence nor result in floundering.
- Assist members in sharing what they are thinking and feeling about what is occurring within the group.
- Teach members basic interpersonal skills such as active listening and responding.
- Assess the needs of the group and lead in such a way that these needs are met.

Exercises

Facilitation of Initial Stage of a Group

1. **Initial Session.** For this exercise six students volunteer to assume the roles of group members at an initial group session, and two volunteer to take on the roles of coleaders. Have the coleaders begin by giving a brief orientation explaining the group's purpose, the role of the leader, the rights and responsibilities of the members, the ground rules, group process procedures, and any other pertinent information they might give in the first session of a group. The members then express their expectations and fears, and the leaders try to deal with them. This lasts for approximately half an hour, and the class members then describe what they saw occurring in the group. The group members describe how they felt during the session and offer suggestions for the coleaders. The coleaders can discuss with each other the nature of their experience and how well they feel they did, either before any of the feedback or afterward.
2. **The Beginning Stage of a Group.** This exercise can be used to get group members acquainted with one another, but you can practice it in class to see how it works. The class breaks into dyads and selects new partners every 10 minutes. Each time you change partners, consider a new question or issue. The main purpose of the exercise is to get members to contact all the other members of the group and to begin to reveal themselves to others. We encourage you to add your own questions or statements to this list of issues:
   - Discuss your reservations about the value of groups.
   - What do you fear about groups?

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- What do you most want from a group experience?
- Discuss how much trust you have in your group. Do you feel like getting involved? What are some things that contribute to your trust or mistrust?
- Decide which of the two of you is dominant. Does each of you feel satisfied with his or her position?
- Tell your partner how you imagine you would feel if you were to colead a group with him or her.

3. **Meeting With Your Coleader.** Select a person in your class with whom you might like to colead a group. Explore with your partner some of the following dimensions of a group during the initial stage:
   - How would both of you assist the members in getting the most from this group? Would you be inclined to discuss any guidelines that would help them be active members?
   - How would the two of you attempt to build trust during the initial phase of this group?
   - How much structuring would each of you be inclined to do early in a group? Do both of you agree on the degree of structure that would help a group function effectively?
   - Whose responsibility is it if the group flounders? What might you do if the group seemed to be lost at the first session?
   - What are some specific procedures each of you might use to help members define their personal goals regarding what they want to explore in a group?
4. **Brainstorming About Ways of Creating Trust**. In small groups explore as many ideas and ways you can think of that might facilitate the establishment of trust in your group. What factors do you think are likely to lead to trust? What would it take for *you* to feel a sense of trust in a group? What do you see as the major barriers to the development of trust?
5. **Assessing Your Group.** If there is an experiential group associated with your group class, assess the degree to which the characteristics of your group are similar to the initial stage described in this chapter. What is the atmosphere like in your group? What kind of group participant are you? What is your degree of satisfaction with your group? Are there steps you can take to bring about any changes you may want to see in your group? To what degree is trust being established, and what is the safety level in the group? What kinds of norms are being formed at this early stage?

Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook

Here are some suggestions for making the best use of this chapter along with the initial stage segment of the first program, *Evolution of a Group*. If you are not viewing the DVD (*Groups in Action*) in class or working with this program, skip the following exercises.

1. **Group Characteristics of the Initial Stage.** Think about how the characteristics described in this chapter are evident in the initial stage of the group depicted in the DVD. What are the members anxious about, and how safe did most of them feel

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from the very beginning? What early concerns did the members voice? Are there any potential hidden agendas? If so, what might they be? What process is being employed to help the members get acquainted?

2. **Creating Trust: Leader and Member Roles.** Trust issues are never settled once and for all. As you view the first section of the DVD, how would you describe the level of trust during the initial stage in this group? Think about ideas for facilitating trust in groups you will lead. What factors do you think are likely to lead to trust? What would it take for you to feel a sense of trust in a group? What are the major barriers to the development of trust? What are some specific fears members raised, and how were these fears dealt with during this initial session? What did you learn about some ways to create trust in a group by viewing the early phase of this group?
3. **Identifying and Clarifying Goals.** If you were leading this group, would you have a clear sense of what the members wanted to get from the group experience?
4. **Group Process Concepts at the Initial Stage.** Structuring is an important process during the early phase of a group. What kind of structuring did you observe us providing? How might you provide a different kind of structuring if you were leading or cofacilitating this group? How did we deal with the issue of cultural diversity that emerged early in the life of the group? What specific norms are we actively attempting to shape early in this group?
5. **Opening and Closing Group Sessions.** Notice the use of the check-in and the check-out procedures in the DVD. What techniques would you use to open a session in a group you are leading? What did you learn about leader interventions in getting members to check in and state how they would like to use time for a session? What specific techniques for ending a session did you read about and also observe in the DVD? What are some lessons you are learning about the importance of bringing a group session to a close?
6. **Using the Workbook With the DVD.** If you are using the DVD and workbook, refer to Part 2: Initial Stage of the workbook and complete all the exercises. Reading this section and addressing the questions will help you conceptualize group process by integrating the text with the DVD and the workbook.

MindTap for Counseling

Additional resources can be found on CengageBrain.com and by logging into the MindTap course created by your professor. There you will find a variety of study tools and useful resources that include quizzes, videos, interactive exercises, and more.

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